中国新闻周刊
English Edition

NEWS CHINA

Volume No.218 October 2026

LIFE

Bionic Buddies: Companion robots coming online

ECONOMY

K-shaped Shift: Tech surges as legacy sectors lag

WINGS OF DESIRE

Conservation soars as birdwatching takes flight

$4.99
10
0 74851 08841 8
$4.99

“With bronze as a mirror, one can correct one's appearance; with history as a mirror, one can understand the rise and fall of a state; with people's experience as a mirror, one can distinguish right from wrong.”

Li Shimin (598-649), Tang Dynasty emperor

Take our podcast The Context as a mirror for insight into China's latest developments from a historical perspective.

Find us on Apple Podcasts, Spotify, Google Podcasts, Amazon Music, Player FM, Stitcher, iHeartRadio, TuneIn, Podchaser, Listen Notes, Podcast Addict, Podcast Index, Pocket Casts, Podbean, Podcast Go, Snipd, AntennaPod, Deezer, Overcast, Castro, Castbox, Podfriend, Goodpods, and RSS Feed.

China needs to turn paid leave from paper right into reality

Recently several provinces, from less developed to prosperous ones, have placed the provision of paid annual leave at the forefront of their policies, aimed at boosting consumption.

In the Special Action Plan to Boost Consumption, released in March 2025, the central government called for stricter implementation of the paid annual leave system and encouraged flexible and staggered vacations.

The 2026 Government work Report, released in March this year, explicitly called to implement a system of staggered paid leave for employees for the first time. More recently, the State Council approved the 15th Five-Year Plan for Expanding Consumption, which pledges to revise the regulations governing paid annual leave, and more effectively enforce the system.

China established a statutory paid annual leave system in 2008. Employees who have worked continuously for at least one year are entitled to five to 15 days of paid annual leave, depending on their cumulative years of service. Annual leave can be taken in one block or in stages, while unused leave due to work requirements must be compensated at 300 percent of the employee's daily wage.

But for many Chinese workers, paid leave remains a right largely on paper. Government agencies, public institutions, large State-owned enterprises and foreign-invested companies generally have more established leave systems.

However, private employers, particularly small- and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs), worry about replacement costs and compensation for unused leave, prompting some to circumvent the rules by counting team-building or personal leave as annual leave or disregarding previous employment.

Employees may hesitate to take leave because of workplace pressure and economic concerns. As the private sector employs the bulk of China's workforce, it means that millions of workers still find it difficult to exercise their legal entitlement to paid leave.

> As the private sector employs the bulk of China's workforce, it means that millions of workers still find it difficult to exercise their legal entitlement to paid leave

A survey by the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security in 2024 found that Chinese workers were entitled to about 10 days of paid annual leave on average but took only 6.29 days. Nearly half did not use their full entitlement. Among private-sector workers, the average was less than four days, and more than 72 percent had never taken their full entitlement.

To tackle the problem, the government needs to strengthen the enforcement of labor laws, with meaningful penalties for employers that repeatedly violate workers' rights. But it remains unclear how effective the enforcement will be, especially as many private companies are facing economic headwinds.

So far, the government appears to be approaching paid leave partly as a tool to boost domestic consumption, as staggered leave could spread demand for tourism, accommodation and other services beyond peak periods. But the problem of this approach is that it could prompt local governments to resort to administrative efforts, rather than a more systematic way.

The government should be aware that paid leave is primarily a labor rights issue. The role of government is not to tell people when or how much to consume, but to effectively enforce the law. Once that right is effectively protected, the resulting increase in travel, leisure and other spending will be a natural consequence that will last long.

Therefore, the real test is not how many policy documents are issued, but whether a healthy workplace culture can be nurtured so that workers feel they can take leave without jeopardizing their income or careers. ★

NEWS CHINA

Published by China Newsweek Corporation
Publisher: Chen Lujun

Executive Director:
Chen Lujun

Editor-in-Chief: Chen Mengtong
Deputy Editor-in-Chief: Zheng Zhonghai

Editorial Office
Managing Editor: Li Jia
Deputy Managing Editor: Du Guodong
Copy Editors: Kathleen Naday, James Tiscione
Lead Writer: Yu Xiaodong
Senior Editors: Wang Yan,Yi Ziyi
Editors: Xie Ying, Xu Ming, Wu Jin
Address: 5th Floor, 12 Baiwanzhuang South Street, Xicheng District, Beijing, China
Post Code: 100037
Tel: 86-10-88395566
Fax: 86-10-88388045

Art Department
Art Director: Wu Shangwen
Art Editor/Designer: Zhang Dawei

Publishing and Development Office
China Newsweek Corporation
Tel: 1-212-481-2510
Fax: 1-212-545-9118
Email: readers@NewsChinamag.com
Address: 820 2nd Ave, 3B-C, New York, NY 10017, USA

Toronto Office: Yu Ruidong
Address: 51 Halstead Drive, Markham, ON Canada L3R7Z4
Tel: 1-905-604-6150
Fax: 1-905-604-6170

New York Office: Wang Fan, Liao Pan
Washington Office: Chen Mengtong, Sha Hanting
Los Angeles Office: Zhang Shuo
San Francisco Office: Liu Guanguan
London Office: Ouyang Kaiyu
Tokyo Office: Zhu Chenxi
Paris Office: Li Yang
Bangkok Office: Li Yingmin
Kuala Lumpur Office: Chen Yue
Moscow Office: Tian Bing
Manila Office: Zhang Xinglong
Berlin Office: Ma Xiuxiu
Brussels Office: De Yongjian
Astana Office: Shan Lu
Rio de Janeiro Office: Lin Chunyin
Johannesburg Office: Sun Xiang
Jakarta Office: Li Zhiquan

Legal Advisor: Allen Wu

ISSN 1943-1902 CN11-5826/G2

Subscription
Customer Service: 1-800-607-4410
Email: readers@NewsChinamag.com
www.NewsChinamag.com

Hide and Seek

NewsChina looks behind the lens to discover how birders are flocking to nature reserves, offering locals new careers and increased prosperity

18

EDITORIAL
01 China needs to turn paid leave from paper right into reality

POLITICS
14 Legal Reform: **Farewell to Bad Bids**

COVER STORY
18 **Birdwatching Economy:** Nest Eggs/Flight Paths

LIFE
28 Youth Football: **Lofty Goals**
32 AI Companions: **Our Friends Electric**
36 AI Study Camps: **Artificial Promises**
39 Blind Vloggers: **Seeing Differently**
42 Relationship Coaches: **Man Handling**
45 3D Printers: **Printing Pressure**

ECONOMY
48 Non-compete Deals: **Blocking the Exit**
51 Economy: **Krunch Time**

CULTURE
54 Film: **Tickets to Paradise**

INTERVIEW
57 Pickleball Diplomacy: **Serving up Friendship**

OUTSIDE IN
60 Chinese Museums: **Collector's Items**

ESSAY
62 Navel Gazing
63 Phoning It In

04 SNAPSHOTS
08 MEDIA FOCUS
09 VERBATIM
10 NEWS BRIEF
12 NETIZEN WATCH
53 CHINA BY NUMBERS
55 CHINESE YOUTH BY NUMBERS
64 GOOD TASTE/REAL CHINESE

39 A staged video has left blind vloggers fighting skepticism as they use social media to challenge stereotypes

42 Relationship gurus promise women greater control, but critics question the empowerment they're selling

48 China is tightening rules on non-compete deals as more companies use them to restrict workers' mobility

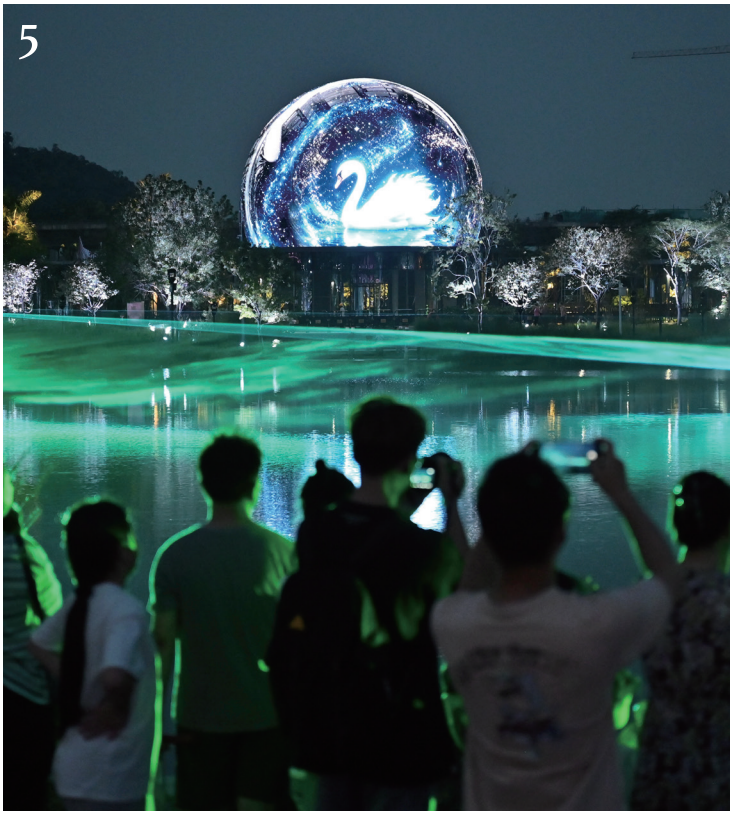
54

1

2

3

4



1. Villagers on specially-designed boats zigzag through an aquaculture pond to harvest water caltrops, Taizhou, Jiangsu Province, August 3, 2026 (Photo by VCG)

2. Mount Heidu attracts tourists for its desolate scenery, Haixi Mongolian and Tibetan Autonomous Prefecture, Qinghai Province, August 7, 2026 (Photo by VCG)

3. A visitor views a glazed Chiwen, a beast used to decorate eaves in traditional architecture, Zhengyangmen Gate, Beijing, July 27, 2026. The 600-year-old gate has reopened to the public after undergoing a six-year restoration to be included as part of the UNESCO-listed Central Axis of Beijing (Photo by VCG)

4. Performers dressed in mermaid costumes swim for audiences at Sunac Ocean World, Kunming, Yunnan Province, August 2, 2026 (Photo by IC)

5. People view a trail performance of the Maritime Silk Road Light Show on the 16-meter-wide Golden Fuxu Pearl spherical screen at Fuxu Ancient Canal, Huangpu District, Guangzhou, Guangdong Province, August 6, 2026. Essential to the ancient Maritime Silk Road, the canal served as a vital route for commercial ships from both China and abroad (Photo by IC)

1

2

4

5

1. Mongolian wrestlers perform at the opening ceremony of Naadam, a 800-year-old traditional sports event comprising horse racing, archery and wrestling, Xilingol League, Inner Mongolia Autonomous Region, July 18, 2026 (Photo by VCG)

2. Students participate in a watermelon-eating contest, Sihe Primary School, Hefei, Anhui Province, August 5, 2026 (Photo by VCG)

3. Two red pandas lick ice cubes to cool down during a heatwave, Enjoyland Animal Kingdom, Zhengzhou, Henan Province, July 8, 2026. (Photo by VCG)

4. Tourists join locals in celebrating the Yi Torch Festival, Shilin Yi Autonomous County, Kunming, Yunnan Province, August 6, 2026. For more than a millennium, the festival has been celebrated to summon blessings for a good harvest, health and happiness (Photo by VCG)

5. Tourists stand in the shade of a tethered balloon as part of a cultural event at Zhangye UNESCO Global Geopark, Gansu Province, August 4, 2026. The park is known for its unique Danxia landforms (Photo by VCG)

Wild Hikers Need More Respect for Nature

China Newsweek July 13, 2026

Despite growing popularity for outdoor activities involving about 400 million participants across China, the most desirable destinations have closed access to off-trail trekkers. After the number of accidents soared by 41.2 percent year-on-year and pollution and trash threaten the environment of nature reserves, local governments have expanded prohibited zones. However, their one-size-fits-all measures such as encircling nature reserves with razor wire not only fail to deter trekkers, but also jeopardize wildlife by fragmenting their habitats. China's hiking boom started at the end of the Covid-19 pandemic, and with the number of trekkers having tripled from 2020 to 2024, professional hikers and local officials agree that sound development of the outdoor sports industry depends on people's respect for nature.

FIFA World Cup Sponsors Gain Popularity

Yi Magazine July 9, 2026

Involving newcomers, offline promotions and global strategies, FIFA World Cup sponsorship in China boomed, even though the Chinese men's team consistently fails to reach the qualified group stage. In May, lifestyle social media platform RedNote purchased its first FIFA broadcast and short-video making rights licensed by China Central Television (CCTV), the country's exclusive live broadcaster for the World Cup. In June, adidas extended its immersive concept sites for Backyard Legends, a video shot for the FIFA World Cup 2026, to Shanghai's Xintiandi, for brand and FIFA promotion. Chinese sponsors like tech firm Hisense, dairy maker Mengniu and toy maker Pop Mart had an on-site presence at the World Cup. Experts said as a game that reaches three quarters of the global population, the soccer World Cup presents a good platform for sponsors to gain popularity, particularly among the young.

Humanity Needs to Adapt to Extreme Weather

China Economic Weekly July 15, 2026

After a series of heatwaves, typhoons, torrential rains and floods, humanity is enduring much more frequent weather disasters. Since 2020, extreme weather and natural disasters have caused global losses of US$3.6 trillion. To address extreme weather, such as Typhoon Maysak, which drenched Guangxi Zhuang Autonomous Region and Hubei Province in July, China called for concerted efforts nationwide to offset climate impacts, from preventive measures to evacuations. Meanwhile, with weather satellite forecasts and relief deliveries by drone, tech is playing an essential role in emergency preparedness and rescue. China is also rehabilitating ecosystems, developing flood retention capacities and publicizing survival skills to mitigate disastrous consequences. Experts suggest the world pay much more attention to climate change, otherwise drought and rainstorms will continue to exacerbate.

EU Swings Between Carbon Market Tariffs, Cooperation

World Affairs
June 16, 2026

On January 1, the European Union kicked off its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), a carbon tariff system involving steel, cement, electricity, aluminum, fertilizers and hydrogen imports. The scheme levies taxes for embedded emissions in accordance with auction prices under the EU Emissions Trading System (ETS) allowances. As the world's first transnational carbon market set up in 2005, the EU ETS has developed a flexible mechanism of carbon allowances levied on a growing number of industries. China's Ministry of Commerce said the CBAM is an unfair and discriminatory treatment which ignores the country's green contributions. On May 7, China, the EU and Brazil launched the Open Coalition on Compliance Carbon Market, the world's first carbon-pricing cooperation initiative between developed and developing economies. Experts said the EU's swings between tariffs and cooperation reflect the changing landscape of international trade and investment resulting from geopolitical games.

Young Chinese Increase Incomes Through Side Gigs

South Reviews
July 13, 2026

Profiting from professional skills or hobbies, young Chinese people are no longer satisfied with their regular salary. They make handicrafts, tutor or design video games as side gigs, not only to increase their income, but also to expand their abilities beyond the workplace. Considering the high costs and few opportunities in big cities, many youngsters run businesses in smaller cities where costs are lower if they should fail. With increased use of AI, some run small companies to provide tech-centered products such as programs for athlete trackers or navigational aids. By 2021, the gig economy employed 200 million people, about one-seventh of the population. This figure is expected to double by 2036. Amid the growing trend, experts said that whatever the type of employment, dedication is a prerequisite for success.

"How does one explain China's competitiveness then? The answer does not lie in a single policy, but rather in the interaction of industrial organization, human capital, innovation and market scale. China now contains multiple stages of industrial development within one national market. Frontier metropolitan areas coexist with vast manufacturing networks, which creates an internal 'flying geese' structure, moving some production to lower-cost inland regions, that spans much of the industrial value chain. Products can be designed, tested, manufactured and commercialized within a single integrated ecosystem before being deployed across a market of more than 1.4 billion people."

Guo Kai, executive president of the China Finance 40 Forum (CF40) Research Institute, arguing against a June report from the OECD claiming that China's competitiveness relies on government subsidies, in an article published on opinion piece website Project Syndicate on July 17

"Building AI models requires a long-term mindset and the ability to delay gratification, rather than using others' outputs for temporary gains in the leaderboards."

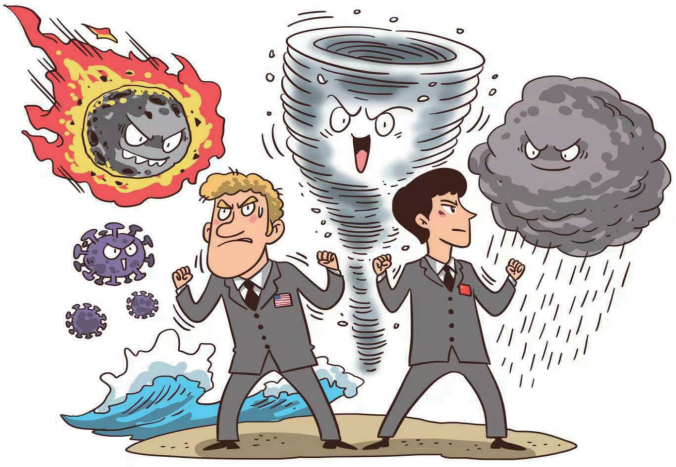
Zhang Yiming, founder of ByteDance, who said at an internal meeting in August that he would not regard distillation as a shortcut to improve AI models

"As a tool of governance, law may face competition [from new technologies], but the core capabilities of legal professionals cannot be replicated by technology. Code can solve technical problems, but it cannot address questions of legitimacy, fairness and justice. Legal professionals can make value judgments and balance interests. They also can construct rules and think in terms of long-term governance, as well as a commitment to humanistic care and protecting rights. These are boundaries that algorithms cannot cross. In this sense, the AI era does not diminish the importance of law. It instead gives law an even more important mission."

Zhang Linghan, dean of the Institute of Artificial Intelligence Law at China University of Political Science and Law, in a interview with news portal The Paper in late July

"AI outperforms humans when it comes to the left-brain but it has yet to develop the right-brain, qualities that include empathy, aesthetics and long-term vision. This is where humans have an advantage over AI, and it has nothing to do with data."

Lee Kai-Fu, founder and CEO of Beijing-based Zero One All Things Technology, at an event promoting his new book *AI: The Future Has Come* at Peking University's National School of Development on August 7



"I once spoke with American scholars and asked them when China-US relations might truly improve. They replied, 'Only when an asteroid hits Earth.' In other words, only when a common external threat emerges will the US set aside competition. But I believe the common challenges humanity faces today, such as climate change, energy crises and public health risks, are that 'asteroid.' These global issues are far more urgent than competition

Professor Wang Fan, deputy director of the Chinese Association of American Studies, at a July forum on area studies and global leadership hosted by the Institute of Area Studies (Chongyang Institute for Financial Studies) and the School of Global Leadership at the Renmin University of China in Beijing

"Every era has its own icons. Seeing the Forbes List rankings change neither surprises or excites me. It only makes me more vigilant. Wang Jianlin was once the icon of his era, just as I was once a young man whom everyone doubted. The cruelest part of change is that those at the top are always the last to notice it."

Justin Sun, founder of blockchain platform TRON and a prominent figure in cryptocurrency born in the 1990s, responding on X to news that he surpassed Chinese real estate mogul Wang Jianlin on the Forbes Real-Time Billionaires List on August 6, with an estimated net worth of US$8.5 billion

"Domestic animation featuring myths is now enjoying a creative boom. Animators have broken free from the stereotype that China's animation industry is still immature and have gained the ability to engage in international cultural expression. At the same time, they face fierce market competition and remain overly reliant on a small number of star IPs. While delivering stunning visual spectacles, they have yet to deepen their thematic expression. They still need to find their way out of the confused and drifting 'Odyssey phase' and reach the ideal land of artistic expression."

Chang Fangzhou, associate researcher at the Institute of Literature, Shanghai Academy of Social Sciences, writing for The Paper's Shanghai Arts column in late July

"To this day, Chinese theoretical scientists still lag behind the world's leaders in original research. I believe one key reason is that our scientists still lack a sufficiently deep grounding in the humanities, so they have yet to fully appreciate or be deeply inspired by the truth and beauty of nature."

Renowned mathematician **Shing-Tung Yau** writing in the Party journal *Qiushi* on August 1

Renewable Energy Focus of Ambitious Green Development Roadmap

China has unveiled an ambitious plan for renewable energy and green tech development for the next five years, aimed at tackling carbon emissions while continuing to grow the economy.

The National Development and Reform Commission (NDRC) and the National Energy Administration (NEA) released the 15th Five-Year Plan for Renewable Energy Development on July 23, outlining a green energy blueprint from 2026 to 2030.

The plan sets systematic, quantifiable development targets covering total energy consumption, power generation, non-electric utilization and reliable grid substitution. By 2030, China's total renewable energy consumption is expected to hit about 1.8 billion tons of standard coal. Total installed capacity of renewable energy power will reach around 3.5 billion kilowatts, with an annual power output hitting 6 trillion kilowatt-hours. Installed capacity of wind and solar power is planned to surpass 2.8 billion kilowatts, which will account for more than 50 percent of national power capacity. Their combined annual power generation is set to exceed 4 trillion kilowatt-hours accounting for 30 percent of the country's total.

The plan highlights innovative reliable substitution mechanisms to address the intermittency of wind and solar resources. By 2030, wind and solar power installations equipped with energy storage should deliver average firm capacity equivalent to 8 percent of installed capacity at peak electricity demand periods. During summer and winter night peaks, wind and solar power is expected to contribute over 20 percent of grid supply. Over the 2026-2030 period, China will add more than 300 gigawatts of reliable renewable peak-generation capacity.

The plan proposes to expand non-electric applications for renewable energy. By 2030, the scale of non-power renewable energy utilization is expected to grow 1.5 times compared with 2025 levels, with renewable hydrogen production reaching 2 million tons annually.

To realize those targets, China will continue to construct large-scale wind and solar bases in desert and Gobi regions, planning to increase installed wind and solar capacity in northwestern, northeastern and northern regions by at least 370 million kilowatts. Offshore wind will be boosted in coastal areas, with cumulative installed capacity increasing by 100 million kilowatts by 2030. The country will also encourage other green energy, improve new energy storage systems, optimize grid connection mechanisms, and coordinate resource development, grid transmission and market consumption.

Two months before the new plan was issued, the NDRC and NEA published a document on implementing compulsory consumption of renewable energy which will take effect as of August 1. An NEA official told media that the compulsory consumption target will encourage key industries to use more renewable energy, advance the green energy market and optimize the distribution of green energy resources across the country.

According to the NEA's latest data, by the end of June 2026, China's total installed capacity of renewable energy reached 2.455 billion kilowatts, accounting for 60.7 percent of the country's total power capacity. In the first half of 2026, newly added renewable energy capacity stood at 117 million kilowatts, accounting for 73.9 percent of all newly built power installations. In the same period, China's renewable energy generated nearly 2 trillion kilowatt-hours of electricity, 9 percent growth year-on-year, accounting for 41.2 percent of total electricity generation.

On July 30, the NEA published its China New-type Energy Storage Development Report, which said that during the 14th Five-Year Plan (2021-2025), the new-type energy storage industry has shifted from the preliminary commercial application stage to a new phase of scaled-up development, with installed capacity soaring from 3 million kilowatts to 136 million kilowatts.

Experts said the new plan upgrades China's renewable energy strategy from large-scale expansion to high-quality growth which prioritizes stability, efficiency and system integration over sheer capacity growth. It will also consolidate China's leading role in the global renewable energy industry and drive global green and low-carbon cooperation.

UNESCO Recognizes Jingdezhen Porcelain Heritage

China's Jingdezhen Handicraft Porcelain Industry Sites was inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List at the 48th World Heritage Committee meeting held in Busan, South Korea on July 25.

Located in northeastern Jiangxi Province, the Jingdezhen heritage site, 7,524.7 hectares in total, consists of five main clusters, 15 constituent components and 45 heritage spots that reflect the entire production cycle, including porcelain production sites, mine sites and material sites. They formed a complete porcelain industrial system for 900 years from the 10th to 19th century.

The UNESCO committee praised Jingdezhen's authenticity and integrity, recognizing its innovative integration with global porcelain-making techniques and arts. It is the world's first heritage site that is themed around porcelain production, and marks the international acknowledgement of Jingdezhen's millennium-old craft and its historic role in cross-cultural exchanges.

The latest inscription lifts the number of world heritage entries in China to 61.

China Rolls Out Security Probe into Imported Printers and Copiers

China's Ministry of Commerce on August 5 announced the country's inaugural national security investigation in the foreign trade arena, targeting imported office equipment with printing and copying functions that feature foreign system software.

The investigation will pay special attention to foreign system software that covers driver software and embedded software developed, tested or maintained by foreign individuals or entities.

Investigators will weigh the national security risks by inspecting the impact of imported products, technologies or services, domestic demand and the extent of reliance on foreign imports, as well as the competitiveness of local office equipment manufacturers and their ability to meet local demand.

The investigation will also examine the impact of relevant foreign government policies and measures on China's national security interests, as well as any other matters affecting national security interests in foreign trade.

A spokesperson with the Ministry of Commerce said the inquiry will abide by legal procedures and protect the lawful interests of all involved stakeholders.

The investigation is to be completed within 12 months of the date of the announcement.

Chinese Scientists Create Precision Map of Moon's Geology

Chinese scientists have completed a 1:5,000,000 global lunar geological map, accompanied by partial geological maps of the Moon's north and south polar regions.

The map's author, the Institute of Geology, Chinese Academy of Geological Sciences, told the Xinhua News Agency that the map, 280 centimeters long and 120 centimeters high, precisely identifies 13,519 impact craters and 81 impact basins across the lunar surface. It also categorizes lunar geological features into 14 types of geological structure and 17 rock types.

Analyzing recent research, Chinese scientists confirmed evidence of volcanic eruptions on the moon as late as 2 billion years ago, extending the known active volcanic history of the satellite by a billion years. Researchers have re-ordered the late-stage geological history of the moon and established an updated lunar chronological table.

China launched the Chang'e-6 lunar probe on May 3, 2024 which successfully returned to Earth with 1,935.3 grams of lunar soil samples from the far side of the moon 53 days later. The same year, China released the world's first 1:2,500,000 lunar geological map. The Chang'e-7 lunar probe is scheduled to launch in the latter half of 2026 to explore the moon's south polar region.

Tourism Platform Ctrip Hit with Heavy Anti-Monopoly Fine

China's State Administration for Market Regulation (SAMR) on July 25 issued a major anti-monopoly administrative penalty against Ctrip, a leading Chinese tourism booking platform, with combined fines and confiscated illegal gains hitting 5.179 billion yuan (US$739.9m).

Based on China's Anti-Monopoly Law, the fine includes confiscated unlawful earnings of 1.658 billion yuan (US$236.9m) and an additional fine of 3.521 billion yuan (US$503m). Authorities also ordered the tourism platform to return 122 million yuan (US$17.4m) of compulsory order deposits to hotel operators. The penalty equals 7.5 percent of Ctrip's domestic sales revenue in 2025.

The SAMR said that Ctrip abused its dominant standing in the domestic online accommodation booking market by forcing some providers to enter into exclusive deals with it and forcing some hotels to give it the lowest prices among competing platforms. Those practices have broken fair market competition, hurt hotel operators and consumers' rights and interest, and obstructed the healthy development of the industry.

Ctrip stated that it would accept the verdict and carry out comprehensive public rectification.

APEC Data Meeting Releases Statement on Cooperation, Innovation

The 2026 APEC Data for Growth High-Level Roundtable was held in Chengdu, Sichuan Province on July 25, where member economies reached a consensus that data has become a new engine for economic growth.

As a core event of APEC Digital Week 2026, the meeting hosted in-depth exchanges over unlocking data value, technological innovation and regional productivity improvement.

In closed-door discussions, participants finalized the APEC Data for Growth High-Level Roundtable Chair's Statement which defines three directions for data cooperation, including fostering an open and enabling environment for data access and use, strengthening data-driven innovation and application, and deepening cooperation on data connectivity.

Liu Liehong, director of China's National Data Administration, said the statement shows that APEC's data dialogue has shifted from "managing data to using data," stressing that data-related cooperation among APEC member economies offers vast market opportunities and huge growth potentials that will open new paths for inclusive growth and shared prosperity.

The latest data from China's National Data Administration showed that China generated 52.26 zettabytes of data in 2025, a 27.28 percent growth year-on-year.

TV family dispute sparks debate over guilt-based parenting in China

Netizen Comments:

- 1."To parents, guilt-inducing education may seem like a way to teach children gratitude, but in fact, it can undermine their self-esteem and confidence."
- "Guilt-inducing education is an invisible blade that harms children in the name of parental love. Parents should take responsibility for protecting their children. Instead, some shift their own hardships onto their children by complaining and venting, forcing them to carry those burdens."
- "In today's society, raising a child is getting harder, and financially supporting a child is by no means easy for a family. Many children seem to fail to understand or appreciate their parents' efforts. Everyone is criticizing 'guilt-inducing education,' but shouldn't children also feel gratitude and respect for what their parents have done for them?"

Source: Zhihu

Media Comments:

Fan Deng, educator and former anchor of China Central Television: "Most people in our generation experienced guilt-tripping education when we were young. But having been through that pain and hardship, we should not pass this parenting approach on to our children. We should learn to treat them with understanding and respect, love them well and, through doing so, heal the wounded child inside us."

Source: Sina Weibo

Zhang Hua, counselor and Shanghai Psychological Society council member: "I can say with full responsibility that the damaging power of 'guilt-inducing' parenting is even greater than that of physical punishment or scolding. At least hitting and scolding lets children know that their parents are losing their temper. Guilt is different. It seeps in slowly, like water soaking into a wall. By the time the wall grows moldy and decayed, you have no idea where it started."

Source: WeChat Official Account

Du Sujuan, Chinese professor at the East China University of Political Science and Law: "The cruelest thing a parent can do is make their children feel guilty. Many wrong choices in life come from guilt toward parents. Many children put themselves in the position of a debtor within the family, while their parents become their creditors."

Source: The Fair

The discussion began after the August 1 episode of the reality show *Her Prime 2*, in which Fang Zhuren (Fang Shaoli), a 51-year old stand-up comedian, hosted a birthday dinner for her younger daughter, who had just turned 18, along with her oldest daughter. The celebration instead became a tense family exchange, with Fang repeatedly recounting what she had endured while raising her children.

Her younger daughter remained largely silent, while her eldest challenged what she saw as her mother's use of guilt in communicating her feelings.

"When I was a kid, she kept telling me, 'The only reason I didn't leave this family was because of you,'" the elder daughter said. "When I grew up, I told her, 'You didn't leave home because of me. You stayed because you were dependent and had no choice.'"

She said her mother's words had made her feel guilty as a child, but that she came to realize after entering university that what her mother had told her was not true.

The exchange resonated with many viewers, who shared similar experiences online and discussed the role of guilt, sacrifice and gratitude in traditional parent-child relationships.

The term "guilt-inducing education" refers to a parenting or teaching approach that seeks to influence children's behavior by making them feel guilty, remorseful and indebted. Parents may repeatedly emphasize the difficult personal choices they have made for their children.

Some netizens said they identified with Fang's daughter and recalled being reminded by their own parents of how much they had given up for them. Others defended parents' right to express negative emotions and called for greater understanding of the pressures parents face.

Some psychological professionals have warned that while guilt-based parenting may encourage children to comply in the short term, it can have negative effects on their emotional development over time. Children may internalize the idea that they are a burden to their parents, contributing to low self-esteem, excessive guilt and difficulty accepting their own happiness.

On August 6, Fang responded to the discussion in a video posted on Sina Weibo. "I will carefully read netizens' comments and learn how to be a good mother," she said.

Extramarital IVF case puts embryo rights in spotlight

A woman successfully fought to have embryos created by her husband and his alleged mistress destroyed after the pair allegedly used a forged marriage certificate to undergo IVF treatment at a Shanghai hospital.

The woman, surnamed Zhu from Wuxi, Jiangsu Province, married her husband, surnamed Tang, in 2006 and have an 18-year-old daughter.

Zhu was diagnosed with lung cancer in 2019. In October last year, she discovered that her husband had created embryos with another woman.

The case was heard in Shanghai on July 30. Zhu sought the destruction of the embryos, 100,000 yuan (US$14,700) for emotional damages from Zhongshan Hospital affiliated with Fudan University and a public apology from her husband's alleged mistress.

However, moments before the court issued its verdict, Zhu received a summons from another local court informing her that her husband had filed for divorce. Zhu said she would not agree to the divorce until the embryos were destroyed.

Tang told media on August 5 that he had formally applied to the hospital to have the embryos destroyed. His lawyer, surnamed Ruan, later confirmed the embryos had been destroyed.

The case drew widespread attention. Li Ningwei, a family lawyer and chairman of the Oriental Family Mediation Center in Shanghai, said on TV program News Workshop that Tang and the other woman had violated assisted reproductive technology regulations by allegedly using forged marriage certificates.

However, Li said this does not necessarily mean the embryos can be destroyed. He said the prevailing view in judicial rulings is that embryos are special entities and that the biological parents have the right to decide their disposition.

INFLUENCER

Wang Hong

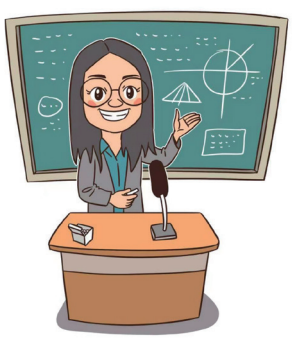
On July 23, Chinese mathematician Wang Hong, 35, was awarded the Fields Medal at the International Congress of Mathematicians in Philadelphia, US. Wang and fellow Chinese mathematician Deng Yu, 37, were among four mathematicians to receive the medal, widely regarded as the most prestigious award in mathematics.

Wang is the first Chinese woman to win the prize. The award recognizes her work in solving the century-old three-dimensional Kakeya conjecture, a longstanding open problem at the intersection of analysis and geometry.

Wang was born in 1991 in Guilin, Guangxi Zhuang Autonomous Region. Her parents were local middle school teachers, and her father taught mathematics. She was admitted to the Department of Geophysics at Peking University (PKU) at the age of 16. A year later, she switched her major to mathematics and earned her bachelor's degree from PKU in 2011. She then continued her studies in mathematics, earning a master's degree from École Polytechnique in France.

Wang later moved to the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, where she specialized in Fourier analysis and geometric measure theory and earned her PhD in 2019. She is now an associate professor at New York University's Courant Institute of Mathematical Sciences.

After receiving the Fields Medal, Wang quickly became a household name on Chinese social media. Some netizens, however, drew attention to her luxury accessories, including a Cartier necklace and ring, and speculated that her annual income could reach 3-4 million yuan (US$445,000-593,000). The remarks sparked criticism from some who questioned whether a prominent academic should be so interested in luxury goods and material wealth.



The debate reflects a longstanding expectation in Chinese society that academic researchers should be indifferent to fame and fortune and willing to live modestly, as if material pursuits were inherently at odds with the pursuit of knowledge.

Others pushed back against the criticism, arguing that scientific achievement does not require poverty and that Wang has every right to enjoy the rewards of her work. Many said that using one's talent to build a successful life with dignity is entirely compatible with being a researcher today.

Why Hyrox is taking off among young Chinese

Hyrox, a hybrid fitness race combining running and functional workouts, has surged in popularity among young Chinese this summer, boosting interest in a new form of competitive fitness akin to CrossFit.

Originating in Germany in 2017, Hyrox combines an eight-kilometer run with eight types of workouts, including sled pushes, sled pulls and medicine-ball work. It entered the Chinese market two years ago and has taken the country's fitness community by storm this year.

More than 10,000 people participated in a Hyrox race in Shanghai in May. According to Yuan Fang, head of Hyrox China, Hyrox has established long-term partnerships with more than 600 gyms across major Chinese cities. On Chinese lifestyle platform RedNote, the Hyrox hashtag has more than 130 million views.

Hyrox China participants are a clearly defined group, Yuan told the *Chengdu Daily*. Most are aged 25 to 40 and work in industries including finance and tech.

"Traditional fitness lacks a standardized competitive format. Hyrox fills that gap with a clear, universal set of rules, and that gives people a tangible way to track their progress and push their own limits," Yuan said.

Legal Reform

Farewell to Bad Bids

China unveils the biggest overhaul of its Government Procurement Law in 23 years to curb corruption and level the playing field for businesses

By Li Qinhua and Yu Xiaodong

On June 23, the Chinese government submitted a draft amendment to the Government Procurement Law to the Standing Committee of the 14th National People's Congress (NPC) for first reading, before releasing it for public consultation on June 26.

The amendment marks the first comprehensive revision to the Law since the legislation took effect in 2003. Expanding the Law from nine chapters and 88 articles to 10 chapters and 104 articles, the amendment is described by legal experts as one of the country's most significant institutional reforms aimed at reducing corruption, strengthening market competition and modernizing public spending.

Hidden Corruption

At an NPC Standing Committee meeting on June 23, Hao Peng, deputy chair of the NPC's Financial and Economic Affairs Committee, said the draft amendment is designed to address legal loopholes exposed by China's rapidly evolving economy.

Official data shows that China's government procurement market expanded about 33-fold, from 101 billion yuan (US$14.9b) in 2002 to 3.3 trillion yuan (US$487.6b) in 2025, while its share of GDP rose from 0.8 percent to 2.4 percent.

Citing persistent problems such as bid rigging, discriminatory procurement requirements, disorderly low-price competition, incomplete procurement rules and weak oversight throughout the procurement process, Hao said the amendment is intended to create a fairer and more transparent procurement system by ensuring equal market access, strengthening legal remedies, reducing opportunities for rent-seeking and tightening anti-corruption safeguards.

In December 2025, the Ministry of Finance published 10 examples of "typical" procurement violation cases, illustrating how procurement requirements have sometimes been tailored to benefit preferred suppliers. In one case, a university laboratory required suppliers to respond to procurement notices within 24 hours, effectively excluding bidders from outside the local area. In another, a government agency used criteria such as business premises, workforce size and total sales to evaluate bids, creating barriers for small- and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs).

A third case involved bid rigging, with three companies coordinating their bids through shared personnel and nearly identical tender documents to create the appearance of competition. The firms were fined and barred from government procurement for one year.

In July, the Ministry of Finance released another eight penalty notices after a nationwide inspection of government procurement, involving discriminatory tender requirements, improper fees charged by procurement agencies, suppliers submitting false documents and bid rigging.

Invisible Barriers

None of the cases publicized involved direct bribery, but they highlight how corruption and unfair competition can be embedded in the procurement process itself.

According to Zhan Ana, a lawyer at Jincheng Tongda & Neal's Shenzhen office, a major problem in government procurement is that tenders often use seemingly innocuous conditions as vehicles for rent-seeking. "Many of these conditions only appear fair on the surface but they are exclusionary in reality," Zhan told *NewsChina*.

Such hidden barriers impose significant costs on smaller businesses before they even have a chance to compete. For example, although the Ministry of Finance has long prohibited procurement platforms from charging fees for downloading electronic tender documents, enforcement has been uneven, and some local authorities continue to impose charges.

Zhan cited the example of an SME that must first pay a 500 yuan (US$74) fee to obtain tender documents, only to discover that it does not meet the eligibility requirements. While the amount may seem modest, if a company typically wins only one out of every 100 bids, it would have to spend around 50,000 yuan (US$7,400) on document fees to secure a single contract. "These hidden barriers accumulate over time and ultimately shut many SMEs out of the market," she said.

The new law seeks to address these issues by strengthening equal market access and improving transparency. It prohibits authorities from unlawfully restricting suppliers from competing across regions or industries, while requiring procurement opportunities to be publicly advertised to all eligible suppliers.

Closing Loopholes

Beyond tackling discrimination and bid rigging, the draft amendments target other forms of market distortion that have long undermined government procurement.

One of the most common is offering an abnormally low bid, in which suppliers submit unrealistically low prices to win contracts, only to cut corners during implementation or seek to recover losses through contract changes later. Xiao Beigeng, a professor at the Law School of Hunan Normal University who has long studied government procurement reform, said that both excessively high and abnormally low contract bids are often symptoms of corruption or procedural weaknesses.

To address the problem, the draft grants evaluation committees greater authority to reject suspiciously low bids. It requires suppliers whose offers are significantly lower than the government budget ceiling to provide evidence that they can still meet contractual obligations, and the committee can reject the bid upon concluding that quality or performance would be undermined. The provision reinforces a Ministry of Finance notice issued earlier this year requiring stricter scrutiny of abnormally low bids, signaling a shift away from awarding contracts solely on the basis of the lowest price.

Another problem is a practice known as "accompanying bids," where firms enter tenders not to compete, but to meet the legal minimum number of bidders required for a procurement to proceed. Under the current rules, tenders are canceled if fewer than three suppliers participate, creating an incentive for entities to submit token bids.

The draft relaxes that requirement, allowing evaluation to proceed after a re-tender even if only two qualified suppliers remain. If only one supplier qualifies after the second round, the procuring entity may, with approval, switch to single-source procurement. The changes aim to reduce incentives for sham competition by removing an arbitrary numerical threshold.

For Professor Xiao, the roots of procurement corruption often lie much earlier than the bidding stage. "When procurement requirements are not clearly defined, they create room for all kinds of rent-seeking," Xiao said.

The changes seek to address a long-standing weakness in China's procurement system: its focus on awarding contracts, with a complete lack of oversight of project delivery.

Article 60 of the draft introduces a formal acceptance mechanism requiring procuring entities to establish

inspection teams and verify contract performance against agreed standards.

To achieve this, the amendments establish a whole-process management system covering budget preparation, procurement demand assessment, procurement, contract execution, acceptance and final performance evaluation. Xiao said it brings the entire process, from budget preparation to final performance evaluation, under a unified legal framework.

For public service procurements, inspection results must be disclosed, and actual service users, not just purchasing agencies, should participate in the acceptance process where appropriate.

Change in Philosophy

Another major highlight of the draft amendment is rather conceptual. The existing law states that open tendering should be the primary method of government procurement. That wording disappears from the draft.

According to Wang Conghu, a professor at the Renmin University of China's School of Public Administration who participated in preliminary consultations on the legislation, decades of implementing existing procurement standards have created a deeply ingrained mindset of open tendering.

"For a long time, the consensus has been that open tendering is the fairest and most objective procurement method," Wang told *NewsChina*.

But that assumption does not always hold. Jiao Hongbao, an associate professor of law at Tianjin Foreign Studies University, wrote in an article published in *China Government Procurement News* on June 30 that it is particularly problematic for technically complex projects, such as large-scale equipment procurement or information systems, where procuring entities often do not know the optimal technical solution when the process begins. Requiring suppliers to submit one-off quotations before technical discussions take place can result in inflated prices or substandard outcomes.

The draft amendments therefore significantly expand the use of competitive negotiations for technically complex projects and those requiring suppliers to help develop technical solutions. For many experts, the adjustment reflects years of practical experience finally being recognized by lawmakers.

"I think this is rational institutional design," Wang said. "It leaves an appropriate degree of discretion for procuring entities and regulators."

The wider use of competitive negotiations, however, raises concerns about rent-seeking and hidden barriers to competition, as the procedure gives evaluation experts greater discretion. To address the new problem, the draft tightens oversight by making them directly accountable under the law. It stipulates establishing a national and provincial expert database with a dynamic removal mechanism and imposes tougher penalties for misconduct.

Experts who violate evaluation rules, fail to recuse themselves over conflicts of interest, or collude with suppliers could face fines and temporary or even lifetime bans from government procurement evaluations.

Role of SOEs

State-owned enterprises (SOEs) have long been seen as a high-risk area for corruption and rent-seeking. Whether SOEs that provide public services and utilities should be brought within the scope of the Government Procurement Law has therefore been a longstanding focus of debate.

An earlier draft published in 2022 included such provisions. The latest draft does not. According to Wang, the omission reflects differing views among government agencies.

Some departments involved in negotiations over international agreements such as the WTO Government Procurement Agreement and the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP) argued that China should leave greater room for opening its procurement market to facilitate international negotiations.

Others believe the timing is not yet appropriate. The resulting compromise appears in Article 99, which extends the law to "other entities" covered under international procurement treaties joined by China.

Wang said the term "other entities" is widely understood to refer to SOEs and was deliberately left undefined to preserve flexibility for future international negotiations. If China makes reciprocal market-opening commitments under agreements such as the CPTPP, SOEs could be brought within the scope of the Government Procurement Law.

In the meantime, Article 31 requires procurement projects financed with both budgetary and non-budgetary funds to be governed by the rules applicable to budget-funded procurement. According to Professor Xiao, it means that in practice, once public funds are involved, the entire project, including non-budgetary funds from SOEs, would be subject to the law.

"In effect, this indirectly expands the law's scope," Xiao said.

'Practical Compromise'

Another closely watched aspect is whether the draft can ease the long-running friction between China's Government Procurement Law and the Tendering and Bidding Law, two parallel legal frameworks that often leave officials and businesses uncertain about which rules apply.

The conflict is most evident in government-funded construction projects, where procurement financed with

Staff provide hands-on guidance to vendors on how to register for the Zhengcaiyun (Government Procurement Cloud), a one-stop government procurement cloud service platform, Jinhua, Zhejiang Province, November 10, 2021 (Photo by VCG)

public funds falls under the Government Procurement Law, while many of the same projects must also comply with the Tendering and Bidding Law's mandatory tendering requirements. Lawyers say the overlap has created years of uncertainty over both applicable procedures and regulatory oversight.

Gu Liaohai, a lawyer known for representing what is described as China's first government procurement lawsuit, said differences between the two laws, from mandatory tendering thresholds to regulatory responsibilities, have caused persistent confusion.

While some scholars have called for a unified Public Procurement Law, the draft seeks to align the two systems. Wang Conghu describes this as a pragmatic approach. "Even if the two laws remain separate, keeping their core rules consistent can achieve much the same policy effect," Wang said, "Compared with pursuing a wholesale legislative merger, gradual harmonization is likely to involve less disruption while delivering more stable and sustainable results."

Whether through strengthening oversight, broadening accountability or laying the groundwork for greater alignment to international practices, the amendments reflect China's efforts to modernize a procurement system that now manages trillions of yuan in public spending.

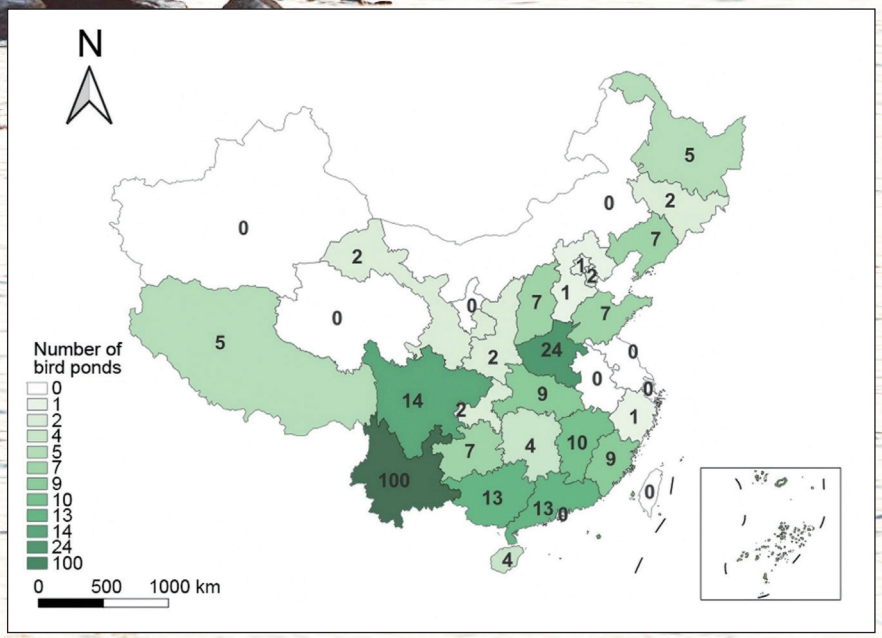
"The government procurement legislation is inherently complex because it governs purchasing across virtually all government departments," Wang said. He stressed that the amendments are in line with the central government's policy priorities, including building a unified national market and promoting fair competition. "Taken as a whole, it represents a major overhaul of China's government procurement regime," Wang added.

Whether the reforms can deliver cleaner, fairer and more efficient public spending, however, will ultimately depend on how the new rules are implemented in practice.★

Birders and photographers gather at Shenzhen Bay Park, Guangdong Province, to view sea birds early on January 1, 2018 (Photo by VCG)

BIRD BRAINS

Former hunters have turned into avian experts to guide enthusiastic birdwatchers and photographers in southwestern nature reserves, boosting sustainable development



Geographic distribution of bird ponds across China as of 2023
(Statistics and graphics provided by Wu Fei)

Birdwatching Economy

Nest Eggs

China now boasts over 340,000 birdwatchers and wildlife photographers, and people in birding hotspots are eschewing hunting for conservation-led tourism

By Wang Yan

Huang Zhiqiang scoops a handful of mealworms from a plastic bucket and walks toward a bird hide. Placing the worms into grooves on bamboo poles above a man-made pond, he blows a whistle. Before long, a variety of wild birds appear.

A chestnut-capped babbler was the first to land. It ate cautiously, and soon flew away. Next came a red-whiskered bulbul, which landed with bright chirps, yet took flight after only a few pecks, yielding its spot to a pair of shamas.

"The chestnut-capped babbler is extremely timid. Locals here in Guangxi traditionally call it the 'ghost bird.' It has a beautiful song, but you can hardly ever spot it. Chestnut-capped babblers are intimidated by red-whiskered bulbuls, so they fly off as soon as bulbuls turn up. When shamas arrive, especially male shamas, the bulbuls get scared, as shamas are far more aggressive," Huang said, sitting in a hide five meters from the pond.

Huang, 43, has become an expert on bird behavior. He lives in Nonggang Village in the karst landscapes of southwest Guangxi Zhuang Autonomous Region. Famous among ornithologists and birders worldwide as the site where the Nonggang babbler, a bird endemic to China, was first identified, the village and nearby nature reserve is a sought-after birdwatching destination. Most villagers have benefited from birdwatching tourism, building ponds and hides among farmlands and woodlands. Huang is among some 40 local professional guides.

In spring and summer, there is abundant natural food, so wild birds do not require supplementary feeding. Even so, Huang often rides his electric scooter to his bird pond. Sometimes he sits quietly in a chair, occasionally putting out a handful of feed and blowing his whistle. "I just want to see whether the birds will come and what time they arrive."

Apart from common resident species, Huang's pond is known for chestnut-capped babblers and yellow-eyed babblers, attracting wildlife photographers between September and March.

Su Shangzhu, Party secretary of Zhubu Township, which administers Nonggang, told *NewsChina* that the village has laid out more than 30 birdwatching ponds, with 12 trails that cover a range of habitats and species. Ten villages participate in birdwatching tourism, benefiting 344 households with 1,422 residents. Families can earn on average 20,000 yuan (US$3,000) more a year, with some earning more than 100,000 yuan (US$14,800).

Taking Flight

Nonggang's birdwatching boom began with the discovery of a new species. In 2005, ecologist Jiang Aiwu from Guangxi University's College of Forestry and his supervisor, renowned ornithologist Zhou Fang, found an unknown babbler population in the seasonal rainforest of Nonggang National Nature Reserve. Formally documented and named the Nonggang babbler (*Stachyris nonggangensis*), it is one of the rare bird species independently discovered, described and named by Chinese ornithologists after 1949.

Located in southwest Guangxi and established in 1979, Nonggang National Nature Reserve covers over 10,000 hectares. It is China's sole protected zone dedicated to seasonal rainforests in its northern tropical limestone region, sheltering rare flora and fauna including white-headed langurs, François' langurs, Nonggang babblers, *Parashorea chinensis,* an endangered evergreen tree, cycads and golden camellias.

Researchers have recorded vascular plant species and 429 vertebrates, including 66 mammals, 66 reptiles, 31 amphibians and 266 birds, accounting for 36 percent of Guangxi's total bird species. "Out of the 266 documented bird species, only dozens appear regularly. About 10 are really sought-after by birders," Nong Zhengquan, chief of the reserve's Forestry Administration and Resources Protection Section, told *NewsChina* in early July.

Jiang noted that the Zhuang ethnic group who live in the area possess

Nonggang Bird Lodge, July 4, 2026 (Photo by CNS)

knowledge that was crucial to finding the Nonggang babbler, and often had their own names for species. "Rangers shared bird descriptions with me – for example, a curved-beaked bird that spends most of its time on the ground,' he said. Nong Weihong, a former ranger, pioneer bird guide and founder of Nonggang's first birdwatching homestay, spoke of a species called "swing bird," named for its hanging treetop nests, which Jiang later identified as the long-tailed broadbill.

After Jiang's research confirmed Nonggang babblers lived in and around Nonggang Reserve, birders from home and abroad flocked there. It led to the development of community-led birdwatching tourism outside the reserve's boundaries.

"Liuzhou Birdwatching Society from Guangxi was crucial in the industry's early phase. I first took its members into mountains searching for the Nonggang babbler. Recognizing Nonggang's birdwatching potential, they backed Nong Weihong to convert buildings into visitor accommodation," Jiang said. Around 2015, farmers began building artificial feeding ponds to attract wild birds.

"Nong Weihong created photography hides using kapok blossoms and mealworms. Photographers paid around 80 yuan (US$11.8) each. A single hide could hold over a dozen people, generating steady daily revenue." Jiang said birdwatching has lifted incomes and boosted wildlife conservation awareness. He never anticipated discovering a new bird would transform livelihoods in this remote mountain region.

News of the Nonggang babbler rippled across the global birdwatching community. Visitors soon discovered other targets: the Indochinese green magpie, brown-breasted hill partridge, white-browed piculet, blue-backed pitta and long-tailed broadbill.

Huang Zhiqiang started working as a guide around 2008. Before that, his family earned 30,000 yuan (US$4,443) annually growing sugarcane. "I knew nothing about birds. I learned from training sessions hosted by the township government and nature reserve, featuring lectures from invited experts."

Today he runs Nonggang Bird Lodge, a three-story homestay completed in 2014, which can host 30 guests. Birdwatching has two peak seasons: late September to March for pond photography, and April to late June for the breeding season, ideal for nest shots. During these seasons, Nonggang's 15 homestays are usually fully booked.

Huang Haipeng used to work in neighboring Guangdong Province. Lured by birdwatching opportunities, he returned home around 2014 to become a bird guide. After years of accumulating capital, he invested 800,000 yuan (US$118,500) to open Xiaopeng Inn in 2022. The inn has 14 rooms, and his family manages two ponds known for Indochinese green magpie sightings.

According to Huang Haipeng, combined revenue from homestays, photography hides, transport and guiding brings his family at least 100,000 yuan (US$14,800) annually, far more than his salary in Guangdong.

Local communities have formed clear systems for labor division and profit sharing. Homestay operators provide lodging, meals and transport, while revenue from photography hides belongs to pond owners. During breeding season, if stable nesting sites are located, photography fees are paid to the pond owner who first found the nest.

Beak Practice

Villagers once relied on mountain resources for survival, with hunting and trapping wild birds long entrenched. Poaching created sharp friction between villagers and staff in Nonggang Reserve.

Zhao Wenqing, president of Longzhou Birdwatching Society, said the illegal trade in wild birds was rife in the 1980s and 90s, driving some species almost to extinction.

In the 1980s to 1990s when the nature reserve was newly set up, household income was low, and some felled trees illegally. "Whenever our staff halted such illegal activities by law, villagers grew resentful. Many believed conservation undermined their livelihoods and resisted our work. This rift persisted for years and proved extremely difficult to resolve," Nong Zhengquan said.

The arrival of birdwatching eco-tourism helped villagers recognize wild birds' long-term value, and they began protecting birds, enabling gradual population recovery. Former bird trappers became professional guides, homestay operators and eco-tourism service providers.

The reserve, in partnership with Longzhou Birdwatching Society, helped villagers design nature trails, build ponds and set prices. The economic benefits they derive encourage them to safeguard forests and prevent logging and poaching, as well as boost conservation cooperation between communities and wildlife officials.

Nong Zhengquan emphasized that the selection of viewing sites must be based on species' natural behaviors.

"Reserve researchers conduct long-term bird surveys to map activity zones, while villagers observe wildlife year-round in the mountains. We combine both datasets to select suitable locations. Observation sites and targeted luring activities are only approved once we confirm regular presence of [certain] species," he said.

But, he added, attracting birds through artificial means is controversial, as feeding and photography can disturb birds.

"For this reason, authorities have introduced formal regulations. Approval for nest photography requires on-site assessment led by Longzhou Birdwatching Society, weighing risks such as nest abandonment or disturbance to fledglings," he said.

This means hides are not close to nests and are rotated every year, with no activity allowed around nest building and hatching. "Everyone understands persistent disruption can drive parent birds to abandon nests, eliminating future observation opportunities," Nong said.

Nonggang's birdwatching sector relies on coordinated support from local government, the nature reserve, research institutions and civic stakeholders. In the beginning there were steep obstacles, such as rudimentary infrastructure, poor accessibility and inadequate sanitation, with no previous foundation for the niche sector.

An Indochinese green magpie with chicks tends to her nest, Nonggang, May 3, 2021 (Photo by VCG)

The reserve and local administrators held discussions in villages to identify priorities. The roadmap they developed called to upgrade basic infrastructure first before making quality improvements. Road surfacing, power grid renovation and full network coverage topped the agenda, while parking, vocational training and village beautification were longer term goals. As more villagers joined in planning and governance, money was allocated to deliver the projects.

From 2017 to 2019, Longzhou County invested over 20 million yuan (US$2.96m) in infrastructure upgrades, including paved roads, kitchen and toilet renovations, drainage systems and parking lots. Guangxi's first dedicated birdwatching hub, Nonggang Ecological Birdwatching Popular Science Base, was launched.

Villagers were the prime beneficiaries, with better living conditions and more income streams. Some built bird ponds and homestays, while others offer tourist shuttles and photography support. Nearly every household has one or two members working in birdwatching tourism.

The reserve directed funding into vocational training for bird guiding, botanical outreach, amphibian and reptile observation, nature journaling, wildlife photography and catering. More than 100 people, mostly young and returning migrants, participated. Officials visited other birdwatching hubs to observe best practices.

Pecking Order

In some parts of China, unregulated expansion of bird ponds has triggered overbuilding, homogenous offerings and cutthroat competition. While individual ponds create limited ecological disruption, concentrated unplanned development accumulates environmental pressure. Uneven profit distribution has sparked internal conflicts. Excluded villagers have damaged facilities and disrupted operations, pushing promising eco-industries toward collapse.

"In the early phase, we shared negative cases of poorly managed birdwatching industries with local stakeholders, repeatedly urging Longzhou to avoid malpractice like unethical bird luring for photos, ruinous price wars, habitat damage through arbitrary tree trimming, and conflicts over exclusive photography spots," Zhong Jia, honorary chairperson of the China Birdwatching Network Alliance, told *NewsChina*.

County and township governments carried out door-to-door outreach, hosted forums bringing together academics, officials and villagers, and rolled out multi-level management regulations.

"A viable replicable birdwatching economy requires inclusive benefit-sharing and institutional governance. If only a small group profits from natural resources, impressive short-term gains

do not amount to a successful development model," Zhong emphasized.

Zhao Wenqing said there is one inviolable rule for photography management: human activity must never disrupt animals' natural behavior. "We do sustained early-stage monitoring to evaluate risks of breeding disturbance and strictly ban trimming vegetation around nests. Any guide altering habitats against regulations will have the site suspended," he said.

A widely accepted set of norms has taken root locally. Whoever discovers a bird nest holds priority to operate the site and earn associated revenue. Simple photography hides require minimal investment, roughly 100-200 yuan (US$15-30) for ground levelling and shade netting.

Globally, supplementary feeding at bird ponds remains controversial. Long-term artificial provision of food may alter avian migration and breeding cycles, shift interspecies competition and increase bird aggregation, raising risks of pathogen transmission.

Professor Jiang Aiwu takes a nuanced stance on bird-pond feeding. "Supplementary feeding in Nonggang mainly runs in the October to February dry season when food and water is scarce. During breeding seasons, birds rarely rely on artificial supplies and retain wild foraging skills. Fixed feeding reduces starvation risks in dry months, with only small periodic portions provided. In addition, visiting birds are not permanent groups, so dependency does not develop," Jiang said.

"There are risks, as permanent feeding spots attract predators such as snakes and raptors. Overall, Nonggang's bird pond model delivers net benefits under current conditions, though consistent standardized management is critical."

Jiang told *NewsChina* his research team has long monitored the ecological effects of bird ponds and nest photography, sharing data with authorities to advance sustainable industry growth. Long-term monitoring shows Nonggang babbler numbers within the reserve are rising.

Zhao Wenqing regularly leads nationwide birdwatching groups to Nonggang. Before visitors arrive, guides design detailed photography schedules based on recent bird activity data. The itineraries target five to six key species through morning, midday and afternoon sites. The focus now is mostly on spring tours.

"Spring coincides with resident birds' breeding season and migratory bird passage, lifting overall sighting diversity. We've extended routes to Mount Daqing on the China-Vietnam border, Longzhou's highest terrain, offering sightings of migrants and unique highland species," Zhao said.

Li Weidong, a 55-year-old bridge engineer and wildlife photographer from Kunming, Yunnan Province, has visited Nonggang four times. "I've traveled to major bird pond photography sites nationwide, most showing obvious signs of heavy human intervention. Nonggang preserves far more natural habitats, and I consider its birdwatching experience among China's finest," he said.

Guangxi birdwatcher Lai Liping visited Nonggang in June, and told *NewsChina* she was impressed with the local guides' knowledge. "They know exactly when birds leave nests to feed chicks, feeding frequencies, primary prey and feeding intervals. delivering an excellent visitor experience," Lai said, adding that accommodation and guiding prices are reasonable."

Sky's the Limit

Across China's karst birdwatching destinations, Nonggang ranks among the finest. Most established birdwatching areas lie in Yunnan, which rely on year-round fixed bird ponds. Nonggang pioneered regulated breeding-season nest photography in China.

Bird pond visits run September to March, leaving villagers with an off-season income gap. Launched in 2019, nest photography fills the March-June void and delivers year-round earnings. They are developing nature education programs like night birdwatching and insect observation to cover July through September. But most remain small-scale initiatives organized by conservation volunteers, and there are no partnerships with big travel agencies.

Nonggang Village employs 25 full-time professional bird guides, alongside seasonal amateur guides such as villagers who discover wild bird nests. While the discoverer manages the site, Longzhou Birdwatching Society specialists monitor it to avoid disrupting incubation.

Nong Qijian, 58, located a red-headed trogon nest in May and built a basic viewing hide. He usually hosts over a dozen photographers daily, but only earned 1,000 yuan (US$148) that breeding season, as trogon chicks fledge in 10 days. Some nests are in difficult terrain, so casual guides face highly unstable incomes.

Nong Qijian's annual household income is around 50,000 yuan (US$7,400), putting his family in the village's lower-middle income tier, but it is not enough to build his own homestay, although there is demand for more lodging.

Jiang Aiwu believes in making sure the whole community benefits. At present, homestay owners and bird guides receive most birdwatching revenue, excluding other villagers, who do not make enough from regular agriculture. He favors Yunnan's collective template where village communities share the benefits, while some skilled operators can earn more.

Visitor Lai Liping feels positive about Nonggang's development path: "The bird pond model suppresses bird trapping and the wildlife trade, allowing villagers to profit sustainably from conservation. I hope the model can be replicated to encourage broader wild bird protection."★

Birdwatching Economy

Flight Paths

Researcher Wu Fei speaks with *NewsChina* about his work developing standards for Yunnan's birdwatching industry that aim to deliver standardized, inclusive and long-term sustainable growth

By Wang Yan

Birders take photos of egrets along the Yuxi River, Yuxi, Yunnan Province, January 24, 2010 (Photo by VCG)

Yunnan Province hosts China's richest bird habitats and avian diversity. Nearly 40 percent of China's over 250 birdwatching sites lie in Yunnan, making it a leader in the burgeoning industry.

Through managing artificial bird ponds, resource sharing and local wisdom, its model has given mountain villagers who once hunted birds the chance to become wildlife guardians, creating an eco-friendly sector driven by community.

Wu Fei is a long-standing expert on avian ecology. An associate researcher at the Chinese Academy of Sciences Kunming Institute of Zoology, he is spearheading the introduction of the nation's first provincial-level birdwatching standards.

In our exclusive interview, Wu shared his thoughts on the opportunities, risks and long-term outlook for birdwatching, and what that means for the future of eco-tourism.

NewsChina: What impact has the boom in birdwatching brought to wildlife habitats and rural communities?

Wu Fei: In recent years, birdwatching has grown quickly in China and attracted more people across the country. But overall, the sector is still in its early stages, developing mainly through spontaneous local efforts. Unified industry standards and top-level overall planning are still absent, yet the overall industrial foundation has been firmly established.

Survey data shows that the number of bird pond sites nationwide exceeded 250 several years ago and it continues to expand. Thanks to its unique ecological endowments and abundant bird resources, Yunnan has the most concentrated bird resources and the most mature birdwatching industry in China.

As a distinctive eco-industry, birdwatching has shown that conservation and rural development can go hand in hand. In the past, wild birds were an important protein source for ethnic communities in the remote mountains of Yunnan. Today, businesses including bird pond operation, bird guiding, rural homestays and catering services provide villagers with stable and sustainable sources of income.

The industry has fundamentally transformed local people's awareness and livelihoods. Former bird hunters have turned into active forest and habitat guardians, voluntarily protecting wild birds. The substantial improvement in villagers' conservation awareness has greatly reduced pressures on nature

reserves and strengthened grassroots ecological conservation.

In villages such as the mountainous Baihualing in the city of Baoshan and Shiti in Yingjiang County, Dehong Dai and Jingpo Autonomous Prefecture, the six-month birdwatching peak season alone generates considerable household incomes. Meanwhile, it drives supporting industries including produce sales and transportation, equipment maintenance and nature education, enabling the whole village to share in the dividends of ecological resources.

The bird pond model provides an innovative solution to the dilemma of ecological protection and economic development in remote mountain areas. It effectively helped villagers lift themselves from impoverishment during China's poverty alleviation campaign. Now, its eco-friendly and people-centered approach pairs with China's rural revitalization strategy.

Practice has proven that the bird pond model forms a sustainable green development system. It activates the ecological value of rural resources, boosts rural revitalization and continuously safeguards regional biodiversity, organically integrating ecological protection, livelihood improvement and rural development.

NC: Some worry that bird ponds and supplementary feeding could harm wild bird populations. Are those concerns justified?

WF: Public anxiety over bird ponds largely centers on risks associated with supplementary feeding. Critics fear constant provision of food will modify wild birds' instinctive behavior, foster food dependency and disrupt natural population cycles. But research conducted at birdwatching ponds in Yunnan shows the adverse effects of properly managed artificial feeding are relatively minor and controllable.

Yunnan has dry and wet seasons. Most bird ponds follow a six-month open, six-month closed schedule. Between October-November and April-May, the dry season creates water and wild food shortages. Bird ponds supply water and moderate supplementary feed to offset these deficits. All feeding stops from late May to late September during the wet season, pushing birds back to full natural foraging. Temporary behavioral changes caused by human activity gradually subside.

Seasonal supplementary feeding in Yunnan is similar in some ways to established practices in other countries, such as backyard bird feeding. In both cases, people provide food to birds to attract them for greater birdwatching opportunities. However, feeding at bird ponds is typically seasonal and is combined with measures like replenishing water, providing concealed viewing areas and following standardized management. This makes it quite different from backyard bird feeding, which is often year-round. Research suggests that carefully controlling the amount of food provided and how feeding is managed can help prevent birds from becoming over-reliant on artificial food sources. So far, no evidence has been found that moderate supplemental feeding leads to significant changes in bird community structure.

Baihualing, a well-established site, hosts just over 20 bird ponds with tightly controlled scale. Long-term monitoring detects no significant shifts in either the species richness or community composition of local bird populations.

We've documented positive outcomes for multiple nationally protected pheasants such as the grey peacock-pheasant and Kalij pheasant. Notably, the Class I protected grey peacock-pheasant has seen considerable population growth, with no detectable disruption to its habitat selection or breeding caused by bird ponds. In summary, standardized bird ponds improve breeding output among medium and large wild pheasants and help populations of threatened avian species recover. The model serves as a viable solution for Southwest China's mountain landscapes.

NC: Baihualing and Shiti are often cited as successful examples of birdwatching-driven rural development. What makes their model work, and what should other regions avoid when trying to replicate it?

WF: The villages' sustained growth hinges on community-led governance with co-development and shared benefits.

Both communities endured chaotic unregulated early development. Initially, a handful of villagers controlled bird pond resources and captured most of the profits, shutting out the majority. Widening inequality sparked frequent conflicts over resources.

Locals came to recognize birds depend on whole forest ecosystems rather than separate ponds. Profit concentration among a few was unsustainable and risked retaliatory ecological damage. Through self-governance, they built a collective revenue-sharing framework.

Bird pond operators now allocate part of their earnings to a communal ecological fund. The fund covers village infrastructure upkeep, forest management, sanitation and unified ticketing. Year-end surpluses are divided equally among all villagers. This multi-stakeholder system stabilizes the industry. Operators retain viable profits, while other residents earn money through bird guiding, transport, homestays, catering and selling local goods. Even local non-participants receive annual ecological dividends, further reducing disputes.

Yunnan's ethnic villages have tight kinship networks and a strong collective consciousness that aid in sharing benefits. The model has attracted delegations from other provinces in China to visit and study it, hoping to draw inspiration from it.

But two key principles must be followed to replicate it successfully. First, local villagers must have the leading role and outside capital cannot monopolize the space. The birdwatching economy

is a niche eco-industry reliant on intact natural habitats. Large external investment, over-commercialization and drastic changes to the landscape harm native ecosystems, crowd out local livelihoods, fuel social friction and betray the goal of ecologically driven rural prosperity.

Second, policies and distribution rules must be tailor-made. Regions vary widely in customs, demographics, development foundations and public expectations. Enforcing uniform formulas could trigger new village tensions. A reasonable income distribution system is also vital. Excessive wealth gaps between bird pond operators and other villagers could breed resentment and destabilize communities.

Nationwide, the birdwatching industry remains exploratory and lacks unified national top-down rules. Its strength lies in flexible grassroots governance. Given China's vast regional diversity, any national standards will require local adjustment. The benchmark for assessing rural industrial models is institutional fairness and public acceptance, alongside tangible ecological and livelihood gains, rather than rigid rules and regulations.

The broader industry rejects compulsory standardized pricing, revenue allocation and operating rules. Respecting organic, locally evolved practices aligns with industrial realities. Local governments and nature reserves fulfill supportive, supervisory and guiding functions while preserving room for grassroots innovation.

NC: What role does local ecological knowledge passed down through generations play in the birdwatching industry?

WF: Communities that have lived in these mountains for centuries have inherited a complete set of indigenous ecological wisdom forged through generations of coexistence with nature. They know exactly which tree species each bird favors, their seasonal activity ranges and hidden roosting spots. This intuitive, place-based knowledge cannot be quickly acquired by outside researchers and bird enthusiasts, and makes up the core competitiveness of local bird guides.

Nevertheless, this valuable traditional knowledge has yet to be systematically sorted and cataloged, and there are few dedicated studies measuring its practical value within the birdwatching sector. Going forward, we can standardize the archiving of these ecological insights and integrate them into the full spectrum of wildlife conservation and bird pond management to fully unlock the potential of their experience for the birdwatching economy.

NC: Yunnan is drafting new guidelines for birdwatching activities and bird pond management. What will these standards mean for the industry's future development?

WF: Few rural industries deliver steady, direct income to ordinary villagers in remote mountain regions. The birdwatching economy is emerging as a practical eco-industry based around communities.

Unlike mainstream cultural tourism, the bird pond model creates a distinctive framework where ecological protection, rural income growth and streamlined ecological governance improve together.

But because the sector depends on unique wildlife resources and high-quality habitats, unregulated expansion is not conducive to its healthy and sustainable development. To address demand for standardized practices in the industry, Yunnan provincial authorities commissioned me to lead the drafting of provincial birdwatching tourism plans, industry guidelines and construction specifications.

Currently, our team is working to finalize the compilation of the Standards for Bird Pond Construction and the Yunnan Province Guidelines for Birdwatching.

Importantly, the new rules avoid rigid, universal numerical mandates such as fixed feed amounts, uniform pond spacing or set photography distances. Bird behavior shifts with seasons, climate and resource availability, rendering static figures unsuitable for diverse ecosystems. Precise regional quantitative thresholds require further targeted research.

Current regulations center on three core ecological and safety bottom lines. First is facility safety standards. Many Yunnan bird ponds are in remote mountainous areas, with steep terrain, posing certain safety risks. Specifications set requirements for viewing hides, platforms and trails to mitigate fall hazards.

The second is wildfire prevention and sanitation rules. Peak birdwatching time coincides with Yunnan's high-risk dry season. The standards tighten fire control and standardize waste management to safeguard forest ecosystems.

Third comes scientific feeding protocols. Permanent year-round feeding is explicitly banned. Operations should follow seasonal cycles, with supplementary feeding concentrated in dry seasons. Permitted foods include mealworms, grains and fresh fruit matching birds' natural diets. Hazardous feed threatening avian health and ecological balance is prohibited.

The provincial standard establishes a foundational framework. No unified, mature international standards exist for bird pond construction and management. Yunnan's emerging provincial standards will steer orderly development across China and offer actionable local experience for global eco-industry governance.

NC: Birdwatching is highly seasonal. How are communities in Yunnan creating more stable, year-round sources of income?

WF: Seasonal fluctuation is intrinsic to birdwatching. The six-month feeding cycle safeguards the ecology and reduces the likelihood of dependence on supplementary food, so intensive year-round operations are inadvisable. To counter

unstable seasonal revenues, established birdwatching villages across Yunnan have adopted integrated "birdwatching plus" models, easing over-reliance on a single sector and boosting off-season earnings.

Three sustainable revenue pillars have emerged. First, nature education and research: Hubs such as Baihualing engage seasoned local bird guides to deliver immersive programs including night insect observation and ornithology outreach. These attract families and student study tours, filling the off-season tourism gap and smoothing annual business volumes. Second, integrated agritourism: Regions around Baoshan have launched distinctive "birdwatching plus coffee" itineraries tied to canopy farming. Local produce and ethnic handicrafts are marketed alongside tourism, converting visitor flows into diversified agricultural income. Third, year-round auxiliary services: Homestays, local catering and short-distance transport operate independently of birdwatching seasons, delivering permanent village employment.

Diversification gradually reduces villagers' over-dependence on bird photography revenue and builds a more robust rural industrial system. In Baihualing, several young residents have returned from cities to run study tour and cultural tourism programs. Still, the number of returnees remains limited. Most are relatives of leading operators. For most villagers, urban employment offers more reliable income than the local birdwatching trade.

NC: Looking ahead, what would an ideal birdwatching industry look like in Yunnan, and what are the biggest challenges to achieving it?

WF: Yunnan hosts over 1,000 bird species, China's richest avian diversity. Its optimal development framework has three pillars. First, streamlined resource management: Authorities should catalogue prefecture-level flagship birds such as green peafowl and great hornbill, document stable viewing periods and create standardized birdwatching route guides to support independent types of visitors.

People view red-billed gulls at Yilong Lake, Shiping County, Honghe Hani and Yi Autonomous Prefecture, Yunnan Province, December 25, 2023 (Photo by VCG)

Second, professional services: Yunnan needs to train local expert bird guides equipped with regional ornithological and conservation knowledge, alongside varied lodging from budget inns to premium eco-homestays, to serve diverse visitors.

Third, coordinated cross-regional development: Following provincial guidelines, interconnected tourism loops with complementary wildlife resources can redistribute visitor traffic across prefectures, uniting avian resources to build nationally famous birdwatching brands.

Major constraints limiting growth exist in physical and service infrastructure. Physically, most bird sites occupy remote mountains with difficult transport. Service-wise, there are no formal training systems for bird guides.

Research on local feeding regimes and carrying capacity (how many visitors a region can support) remains inadequate, while cross-prefecture and interprovincial route coordination progresses need to be strengthened.

NC: As Yunnan develops more high-end birdwatching routes, how can it balance tourism, scientific research and wildlife protection?

WF: I believe the key is to build a virtuous cycle where birdwatching tourism, scientific research and wildlife conservation reinforce one another, rather than being treated as competing interests.

First, high-quality birdwatching tourism generates direct economic benefits for local communities. This economic incentive naturally raises residents' awareness of conservation. When birds become a sustainable source of income, protecting them becomes a shared community interest rather than an external mandate. At the same time, well-guided birdwatching activities serve as a form of public science education, helping visitors understand the ecological value of these species and fostering a broader culture of conservation.

Second, birdwatchers produce valuable scientific data, such as species distribution records, population trends and seasonal migration patterns. This data often covers large areas over time that professional researchers alone cannot achieve.

Third, research based on this data enables scientists to develop evidence-based conservation strategies, such as identifying priority protection zones, understanding population dynamics or assessing the impacts of environmental changes. More effective conservation leads to healthier bird populations and more diverse species, which makes birdwatching destinations more attractive, drawing more tourists and generating further economic returns.

In this way, tourism fuels conservation motivation, conservation enables scientific data collection, science informs better protection measures and better protection sustains the very resource that makes tourism viable. It is a self-reinforcing loop where each pillar strengthens the others. ★

Chinese Football Boy (CFB) head coach Dong Lu poses with his players after their win at the Sigismondi International Youth Cup in Rome, Italy, June 2, 2026 (Photo Courtesy of CFB)

Youth Football

Lofty Goals

China's soccer dreams have endured decades of disappointment. But after a squad of 12-year-olds from an unconventional club defeated some of Europe's top youth teams, experts are now juggling whether to rewrite the country's playbook on developing talent

By Wu Jin

When 12-year-old Meng Xinyi of Chinese Football Boy (CFB) club stepped up to the penalty spot on June 2, spectators at Rome's La Borghesiana Sports Center held their breath.

A goal would seal the Sigismondi Cup, Italy's premier nine-a-side U12 tournament that sees youth teams from top-flight clubs around the world.

At the referee's whistle, Meng sprinted toward the ball and struck it with the inside of his right foot. The shot curled into the net's top-right corner. Although Everton's youth goalkeeper guessed correctly and stretched to his right, he could only watch the ball fly past him.

The young Chinese players and their supporters erupted in celebration. CFB had defeated the Everton youth team, from Liverpool, UK, 5-4 on penalties. Overcome with excitement, Meng pulled off his jersey and celebrated with a somersault.

Led by former sports commentator-turned-head coach Dong Lu, CFB had

scored 21 goals and conceded just two for a perfect 7-0 tournament record.

Even Dong was surprised by their success. "With 48 strong European teams from England, France and Portugal competing, our initial goal was simply to reach the quarterfinals," Dong told *NewsChina* in July.

CFB represents hope for Chinese football, which has struggled to score big on the international stage. The country's last World Cup showing was in 2002, where it failed to score a single goal and was eliminated quickly.

"We entered the tournament mainly to prepare these boys for this year's 2034 Cup," Dong said, referring to the annual U12 tournament he organizes in Suzhou, Jiangsu Province for the 12-year old squads from youth football clubs and schools nationwide. The name "2034" refers to the year Dong hopes China will return to the World Cup finals.

Founded in 2017, CFB scouts and develops talented players aged 12 and younger. Unlike traditional youth clubs, which are mostly pay-to-play, it provides training with professional coaches and opportunities to compete overseas, largely free of charge. Admission is highly competitive, with players selected through a rigorous, transparent process.

But CFB's approach of prioritizing skills and match experience over chasing titles has drawn criticism from China's youth soccer establishment, especially surrounding Dong's lack of coaching credentials. CFB's supporters argue that getting to participate in major competitions like Sigismondi, without simply focusing on winning them, is what benefits young players in the long run.

Young Guns

CFB's championship quickly dominated headlines and social media discussions across China. On Sina Weibo, the victory topped the trending list on June 2.

"Is this how it feels to support a top-flight football team?" a Weibo user from Liaoning Province named Hu Adi commented.

On June 3, the State-run broadcaster CCTV News shared a 21-second video showing Meng's decisive penalty kick and the team's celebration. The clip got nearly 2.3 million views by July 15.

The excitement came amid years of disappointment surrounding Chinese soccer. The ranking of the Chinese men's national team has fallen from 53rd in 1993, when FIFA introduced its rankings, to 91st in 2026. In 2025, the team dropped as low as 99th after losing 1-0 to Indonesia, then ranked around 118th in a crucial Asian qualifier for the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

Plagued by match-fixing scandals, corruption and inadequate training, both the men's national team and the Chinese Super League have struggled to win public trust.

The team of 12-year-olds has reignited hope among Chinese soccer fans.

To celebrate the achievement, real estate tycoon and businessman Li Xiaohua hosted a banquet in Beijing on June 27 for Dong and the young players. "I spent a lot on this banquet not only because I admire their championship win, but also because I have been moved by Dong's efforts over the past nine years," Li said at the event.

This is not the only corporate support CFB has received.

On July 9, smartphone maker Honor sponsored Dong's club, giving each of its young players one of its flagship phones, according to the Xinhua News Agency. Several days later, beverage company Nongfu Spring extended its sponsorship agreement with CFB from three years to five, according to *Zhejiang Daily*'s Tide News.

"Previously, none of our sponsorships lasted more than three years," Dong told *NewsChina*.

Dong said over the past nine years, player training and international competitions cost 58 million yuan (US$8.6m), a major chunk coming from sponsors like automaker BYD.

Dong distributed the tournament's 50,000 euro (US$57,100) winnings equally among the 14 players.

Despite its humble beginnings and criticism over Dong's lack of coaching credentials, CFB has grown from a controversial experiment into a youth training program that has earned rare recognition from mainstream Chinese soccer.

In its early years, the club had no permanent training ground. Players recruited from schools and clubs across China gathered for intensive sessions on rented pitches only days before competitions.

A breakthrough came in 2019, when Dong partnered with the Ma Yuehan Athlete Class at Tsinghua University High School in Beijing, allowing around 20 CFB players to train regularly at the school's facilities for four years.

But the school did not renew the contract. "I was devastated because it felt like all my efforts had disappeared overnight," Dong said. "What consoled me was seeing these players develop."

More than a dozen have gone on to join club programs in Spain or youth teams in China, such as with Beijing Guo'an.

Last year, eight of CFB's former players were starters on Beijing's winning U16 men's squad at the 15th National Games, including captain and defensive midfielder Li Dongchen, winger Chen Junhan and forward Zhao Songyuan, who scored the opening goal to defeat Hubei Province 3-1.

The Sigismondi Cup was not CFB's first success in Europe. In 2018, the club's U10 squad won the Wide Star Cup finals, a tournament held in Germany organized by Chinese companies Shandong Wide Star Sports and Beijing Lebo Football. Seven of the eight participating teams were European.

However, the team's 4-1 victory over Germany's Borussia Dortmund U9

squad attracted limited attention. It came during the final years of China's "golden yuan" soccer era, when billions of yuan from real estate companies and other investors fueled overseas projects and heavy spending on foreign players and coaches.

The investment brought short-term success, including Guangzhou Evergrande Taobao FC's two Asian Football Confederation Champions League titles in 2013 and 2015 under head coaches Marcello Lippi and Luiz Felipe Scolari. But the era was also marred by corruption scandals, match-fixing and misused funds.

At the time, youth development received far less attention than immediate results. Now, CFB's rise represents a path focused not on buying success, but on developing young players from the ground up.

Players line up on the pitch at the 2034 Cup 6th Primary School Students Football Tournament, Suzhou Olympic Sports Center, Suzhou, Jiangsu Province, July 19, 2026 (Photo by VCG)

Contested Plays

Debate over Chinese soccer only intensified after Dong achieved what many professional coaches had struggled to accomplish.

In an interview with Sina News on June 18, former Chinese soccer star Sun Jihai, a defender for English Premier League club Manchester City from 2002 to 2008, expressed concerns over CFB's frequent participation in international games, arguing that chasing results at the youth level runs counter to proper player development. "It is like growing crops. You need to wait until autumn, not summer, for the harvest," Sun said.

In 2024, Sun openly recruited young players across the country for his youth soccer club based in Dalian, Liaoning Province aimed at providing equal opportunities for talented players from all backgrounds. The young recruits attend local schools and receive free training and accommodation at the club's base.

It has nearly 90 players from ages 9 to 13, and focuses on developing fundamental skills such as ball control, dribbling and combination play.

But Sun's team has yet to win any major tournaments. On February 13 in Guangzhou, Guangdong Province, the club lost 4-0 to Evergrande Football School in the qualifying final of the Universal Youth Cup International Tournament Apuane, losing access to the ensuing games organized in Italy.

On May 28, its U13 team was eliminated from the provincial qualifiers for the Chinese Youth Football League, a national competition organized by the CFA.

However, to help each club reach its full potential, the Chinese Football Association (CFA) has introduced regional tournaments alongside provincial qualifiers since 2025. As provincial runners-up, HBK qualified for this year's North Region 1 tournament, where they secured a spot in the national top 32 with six straight wins, scoring 31 goals and conceding just two.

While Sun continues to emphasize the importance of technical development, Dong holds a contrasting view.

"Sun is one of the few Chinese players to have competed in both the FIFA World Cup and the English Premier League, so his professional experience naturally shaped his training philosophy," Dong told *NewsChina*.

"But his achievements do not mean my experience with game-based training should be dismissed. Over the past few years, I have led CFB teams in more than 1,000 competitions, including over 400 international tournaments. There is no absolutely right or wrong approach. We have simply chosen different paths."

The debate has also attracted broader attention. On June 9, an article published on the *People's Daily* website argued that CFB's challenge to conventional youth training should not be dismissed as unconventional or short-sighted.

"Let's evaluate Dong's training approach rationally and let time determine whether it is scientific and sustainable,"

CFB forward Jin Minjun (front) celebrates with head coach Dong Lu after their win against British side Everton in a 5-4 penalty shootout to clinch the Sigismondi International Youth Cup, Rome, Italy, June 2, 2026 (Photo courtesy of CFB)

the article said. "What we can confirm now is that China should tolerate diverse training models, as long as they are legitimate and follow the rules of children's physical and psychological development."

It compared the difference in youth training approaches to the relationship between the country's professional Chinese Super League and the local amateur Jiangsu Super League in Jiangsu Province, which has achieved organic commercial success in recent years. While they serve different purposes, they are ultimately complementary.

"With both, the future of China's football development can be strengthened," the article said.

Game Sense

The 2026 World Cup final on July 20 was memorable for Spain's near-perfect tiki-taka style and Lionel Messi's emotional farewell, but also CFB's Meng Xinyi, who was a flag bearer at the opening ceremony.

For many Chinese fans, Meng represents a new generation carrying China's World Cup hopes.

"The Sigismondi Cup victory is already in the past and cannot determine anything about the future," Meng told *NewsChina* on July 13. "I'll cherish what comes next and continue devoting myself fully to football."

His ambition is shared by many young players across China.

Zhou Zhanxu, a 12-year-old student at Changping Middle School affiliated with Tsinghua University in Beijing, wants to become a professional soccer player. His teammate Shi Jian with Beijing Huixin Football Club said he hopes to balance academics and football because he does not want to give up either.

In June, Huixin FC sent Zhou and Shi to Japan's Nara Club, a division three professional team, for a weeklong exchange training program. Shi said it improved his ability to observe the game, make quick decisions and defend as a central defender.

"The training atmosphere was excellent. Nobody chatted or got distracted during the sessions, and I improved a lot in that environment," Zhou said.

While young players remain enthusiastic, their parents are more cautious.

"A child should grow up with a sport that can stay with him throughout his life," Shi Yiheng, a sports lecturer at Henan University of Engineering and Shi Jian's father, told *NewsChina*. "But becoming a professional player is another matter, because the odds of becoming a professional athlete are very low."

"I will support my son entering professional soccer only if he demonstrates not just technical ability but competitiveness as an athlete and continues pursuing his dream every day."

Zhou Zhanxu's father shares a similar view. "We respect his dream and support his dedication to the sport, but we won't push him to be a professional player," Zhou Hang said. "His health and education are our top priorities."

According to the head coach and owner of Beijing Huixin FC who spoke to *NewsChina* using only his surname Chai, China's exam-oriented education system forces many passionate young players to abandon soccer after primary school.

"But we don't want to simply follow the broader environment," Chai said. "Since 99 percent of the children at our club still want to continue training after primary school, we provide three training sessions and one match every week, just like at Nara Club."

In February 2024, China's General Administration of Sport issued document on encouraging the expansion of campus soccer programs and training bases. The document set a goal for China's boys' and girls' youth teams in various age groups to reach leading positions in Asia by 2030.

A year later, the number of registered amateur soccer players aged 21 and under reached 109,220, an increase of 16,241 from the previous year, according to the Chinese Football Association. However, the figure is less than one-seventh of Japan's registered players, the *People's Daily* reported.

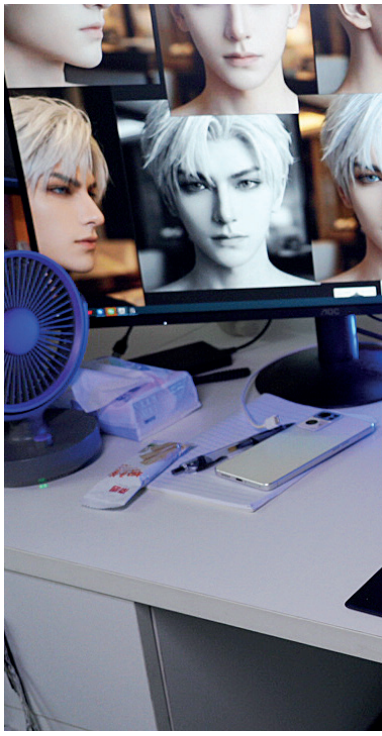
Following Meng's performance in Italy, his hometown of Nanjing, Jiangsu Province said it would support his overseas training, his father Meng Qinghua told *NewsChina*.

"The local government and school promised to preserve Meng's enrollment status if we decide to send him abroad," his father said. "That gives us an important safety net if overseas training does not work out.'

"Our family discussed this carefully. We know overseas training will be challenging and that standing out will not be easy. But we do not want to let such a valuable opportunity pass without trying."★

AI Companions

Our Friends Electric



More than productivity tools, robot makers are aiming to create ultra-bionic humanoid companions capable of providing emotional comfort – and raising some uncomfortable questions among regulators

By Wang Shihan, Yu Yuan and Yi Ziyi

In the 2013 sci-fi film *Her*, Scarlett Johansson voiced "Samantha," an AI operating system that formed a deep emotional bond with the film's protagonist.

More than a decade later, UBTECH is among the latest companies taking a step toward embodying that vision.

At its 2026 global launch event on June 30 in Shenzhen, Guangdong Province, the AI and robotics company unveiled its UWORLD U1 series, a lineup of full-size, ultra-bionic humanoid robots.

The robots, standing between 1.60 and 1.85 meters tall, made their debut with a runway show before waltzing with human dance partners.

Designed for companionship, each comes with large language models geared for emotional development, encrypted memory storage and customizable appearances.

UBTECH is far from the only Chinese startup entering this field. Unlike humanoid robots designed for manual labor, these companies focus on creating human-like facial features, skin texture, voices and body temperature, while training robots for emotional interaction.

But as these robots increasingly resemble human companions, the boundaries of "companionship" are becoming less clear. Their attractiveness, ability to emote and capacity to simulate bonds put them somewhere beyond the conventional role of a machine. In some cases, companionship may naturally evolve into romance or intimacy, possibilities that are raising new issues for lawmakers about how the industry should be regulated.

Awaiting Orders

For years, humanoid robots were primarily developed as productivity investments that generate high returns. But companies like UBTECH are betting consumers will pay a premium for a friend.

Its new U1 series ranges from the 119,800-yuan (US$17,696) half-body Lite to the flagship Ultra, which has autonomous locomotion and enhanced computing power for up to 999,000 yuan (US$147,568). They also come with male or female appearances.

Speaking at the launch event, Zhou Jian, UBTECH's founder and CEO, said the industry had previously focused on whether robots could perform household chores. Today, however, he believes people increasingly seek companionship, happiness and emotional fulfillment.

His view reflects broader demographic trends. According to the latest data from the National Bureau of Statistics, China's adult single population surpassed 300 million in 2026. That figure is close to the population of the entire US (342.7 million) and exceeds the combined populations of the UK, France and Germany. Nearly one in four Chinese adults is now single.

China is also aging rapidly. According to the National Health Commission, the country's population aged 60 and above reached about 320 million by the end of 2025, accounting for roughly 23 percent of the total population. The commission projects that figure will exceed 400 million by 2035.

Zhou argues that industrial humanoid robots risk becoming little more than hardware products with limited ecosystem potential. But consumer humanoid robots could generate not only hardware sales but also long-term subscription revenue, making them more profitable over time.

On launch day, UBTECH received 13,361 orders, with deliveries slated for September 16. Assuming every order was for the entry-level U1 Lite, that equates to more than 1.5 billion yuan (US$191m), or about 77 percent

Yizhizai's models for its humanoid robots are displayed (Photo courtesy of the interviewee)

Wu Heng (right), founder of Yizhizai, stands next to his company's robot Suyan (Photo courtesy of the interviewee)

of the company's total 2025 revenue. UBTECH aims to produce 10,000 U1 units this year and expand annual production capacity to 50,000 units by 2027.

Toward the end of the launch event, UBTECH demonstrated several of its human-faced robots on stage. Videos shared online showed noticeable mechanical stiffness while walking, as well as clear differences between the robots' real-world appearance and the polished promotional renders released earlier, prompting some netizens to accuse the company of misleading consumers.

Jiao Jichao, UBTECH's vice president, said in an interview at the launch event that the greatest technical challenges in building highly lifelike humanoid robots lie in the head. These include facial muscle movements, coordinated neck motion and binocular vision for eye tracking, all of which require extremely precise control and synchronization.

Uncanny Valley

When it comes to ultra-bionic humanoid robots, prioritizing physical attractiveness is an unwritten rule.

At an office in Shenzhen's Nanshan District, our reporter met Suyan, a female robot developed by Shenzhen Yizhizai Intelligent Technology. Designed for emotional companionship, Suyan is scheduled to be delivered to its first overseas customers in October.

Two Suyan models are displayed in the company's lobby. One sits on a chair wearing a blouse and high heels, while the other stands against the wall in a sporty, casual outfit. Tall and slender, with soft skin and carefully applied makeup, Suyan can be mistaken for a real person from a distance.

Wu Heng, Yizhizai's founder, told *NewsChina* that the team's priority is not hardware specifications or movement performance, but how well the robot matches users' vision of an ideal companion. To achieve that, the company analyzed preferred facial features, voices and personalities from users of Chinese and overseas social media platforms.

Suyan targets male and female users between the ages of 35 and 55. According to the company's research, this group prefers a sophisticated, empathetic and emotionally mature female companion. The team aimed to give Suyan an air of affluence and success, while having the calm temperament of a therapist.

This design philosophy differs sharply from that of general-purpose humanoid robots.

"Robots designed for household chores should be completely separate from those created to provide emotional value," Wu said. "The latter must embody mechanical beauty, from aesthetic appeal to graceful body proportions."

"When designing female robots, we consider waist-to-hip ratios. For male robots, we emphasize defined abdominal muscles and a lean physique," he added.

Besides Suyan, Yizhizai is developing two male robots with "domineering CEO" and "idol trainee" personas, both popular archetypes among young Chinese women.

A staple of Chinese romance fiction and dramas, the "domineering CEO" is a wealthy, alpha-male businessman

devoted to the female lead. The "idol trainee" is a young aspiring pop singer trained under an entertainment agency while building a close connection with fans.

The company is also developing a female robot modeled as a zoology undergraduate. According to the company, social media research found that both men and women favor the image of a well-educated young woman with a career and a gentle personality. A zoology student, it says, conveys intelligence, professionalism and compassion toward both animals and people.

The robot's bionic skin is also engineered to enhance interaction. When users touch the robot, the contact area gradually warms. Its cheeks can heat to 42 C, mimicking the physiological blush of embarrassment.

China already has a large industry producing lifelike sex dolls, which are legal consumer products. Companion robots introduce a significant difference, however, and the legal and ethical questions surrounding them are only beginning to emerge.

In an April 2025 article published on qq.com, Zhou Chuikun, a lawyer at Beijing Yingke Law Firm, examined some of the potential issues surrounding robots designed for sexual purposes. He noted that sexual activity involving a robot would not constitute prostitution because a robot is not a human providing a sexual service.

That does not mean such interactions would necessarily be legal. Zhou said other laws could apply depending on how the robot was designed or used. A robot made to resemble a minor, for example, could violate laws protecting minors, while robots designed specifically to provide sexual services or remotely controlled to engage in sexual acts could raise issues involving obscene materials and electronic information.

But the bigger legal question may be what these machines are in the eyes of the law.

Moya (behind), a bionic companion robot, is designed by Shanghai Zhuoyide Robotics (Photo courtesy of the interviewee)

In a May 2024 article published by the cultural platform Vistopia, Zhai Zhiyong, a professor at Beihang University's School of Law, wrote that Chinese law currently neither prohibits the development of companion robots nor recognizes them as a distinct legal category.

"For now, regulation focuses primarily on safety, while ethical questions remain under observation as society is yet to develop a broader consensus," he wrote.

Zhai noted that lawmakers could theoretically go further, including prohibiting the development of certain companion robots or even banning romantic or sexual relationships between humans and machines. "But such measures would require substantial public support that is not currently evident," he wrote.

In the meantime, the industry's considerations of visual appeal remain a high priority.

On January 30, Shanghai Zhuoyide Robot launched Moya, a bionic robot designed primarily to provide care and companionship for older adults. Unlike Suyan, Moya has pink hair, a round face and deliberately understated features intended to appear warm and approachable rather than conventionally beautiful.

Tang Jun, co-founder and vice president of bipedal products at Zhuoyide, told *NewsChina* that the team considered creating an "influencer-like" face but ultimately rejected the idea. They worried that overly standardized beauty would feel "too artificial."

Experts say highly realistic appearances are a necessity for authentic human-robot interaction. "Combining visual and tactile perception creates a more immersive sense of companionship, compensating for the limitations of voice-only AI, which lacks physical presence and expressive feedback," said Liu Wei, director of the Human-Computer Interaction and Cognition Engineering Laboratory at Beijing University of Posts and Telecommunications.

However, designs must strike a delicate balance. "Excessive realism can trigger the uncanny valley effect, in which subtle imperfections in facial features or micro-expressions create a strong sense of discomfort," he added.

In 1970, Japanese roboticist Masahiro Mori proposed the now-famous "uncanny valley" hypothesis. It suggests that once a robot becomes almost human in appearance, even tiny unnatural details can result in feelings of unease, repulsion or even fear.

For more than two decades, researchers and manufacturers have worked to overcome this psychological barrier.

Cao Rongyuan, founder of Wulun Technology, whose company developed a multimodal bionic facial robot called Annie, told *NewsChina* that subtle natural movements are key.

Functions such as gaze tracking, sustained eye contact and precisely synchronized lip movements all depend on close integration between mechanical design, motion control and interaction algorithms.

Cao recalled that early versions of Annie could match mouth movements only to a limited set of pre-programmed speech segments. During live conversations, lip movements lagged speech by

200 to 300 milliseconds, far from bridging the uncanny valley.

To solve the problem, the company redesigned the robot's cranial structure to accommodate additional micromotors, enabling more nuanced facial movements such as pouting and pursing the lips. Building on a general lip-motion model, the team then collected Chinese pronunciation data, refined its control algorithms for different mouth shapes and developed a predictive precomputation system. The result was a reduction in lip-sync delay to less than 50 milliseconds, less perceptible to the human eye.

Fully Charged

Although Suyan has yet to be delivered, some customers have already begun treating her as more than a product. Wu Heng told *NewsChina* that about 400 are part of a WeChat group for early customers, where they create Suyan emojis and share photos of accessories and clothing they have prepared for her. Many have already begun treating her as a real person with a distinct personality.

To Wu, this reflects a deeper emotional need. "Users have found a way to ease their loneliness," he said.

One customer left a lasting impression on Wu. An overseas buyer paid full price for a Suyan model to be a companion for his terminally ill younger brother. During his brother's final months in the hospital, the two often talked about Suyan's development and the features she would have.

The younger brother died before the robot was delivered. But the customer chose not to cancel the order, saying that Suyan had become a "bridge of love" connecting him with his brother's memory.

Tang Jun once worked as a caregiver in a nursing home. He found that senior care facilities are rarely short of nursing staff. What many older people truly lack, he said, is someone willing to listen and talk with them.

"These robots have clear practical value in elder care," Tang said. "Beyond conversation, they can guide older adults through exercises and remind them to take their medication."

Even so, lifelike robots are far from becoming the perfect soulmate.

Liu Wei said today's AI systems simulate empathy mainly through large language models, emotion recognition and carefully designed conversational patterns, rather than a genuine understanding of complex human emotions.

"When responses become repetitive or formulaic over long-term interactions, users seeking deep emotional companionship will inevitably feel disappointed," Liu said.

Language is not the only limitation. According to UBTECH, a full battery charge for its U1 series lasts only two to four hours. That means a robot costing nearly 1 million yuan (US$148,061) may need to return to its charging dock after only a few hours of conversation with its owner.

Cai Bingzhen, director of the Gaogong Robotics Research Institute, told *NewsChina* that two to four hours is currently typical for full-size, bipedal humanoid robots equipped with dual arms.

"Although robots can theoretically operate while charging, doing so greatly diminishes the user experience," Cai said. "In home settings, that limitation becomes even more obvious."

He argued that user experience is especially critical for companion robots.

"If users are talking with a robot they perceive as an individual and it suddenly shuts down because the battery is depleted, they are instantly reminded that it isn't warm companionship at all, but simply a cold machine."

Ideal Partners

Liu warned that as humanoid robots become objects of intimate attachment, they could contribute to emotional alienation and social withdrawal. Because robots offer unconditional compliance and conflict-free interactions, some users may become dependent on one-sided emotional relationships while withdrawing from real-life social connections.

"The lonelier people become, the more they may come to depend on machines," Liu said.

These concerns are no longer entirely hypothetical. China has already begun regulating AI companionship services. Jointly issued by five government departments, measures specifically targeting the AI companionship industry took effect on July 15.

Among its provisions, the Interim Measures for the Management of Anthropomorphic AI Interactive Services prohibit designs that encourage emotional dependence or addiction.

They also explicitly ban virtual companions for minors, require reminders after more than two hours of continuous use, mandate interventions when systems detect signs of emotional dependency, and require emergency response mechanisms when users display extreme emotional distress.

In an interview with *Xinmin Evening News*, Li Xueqing, an associate professor at the School of Media and Communication at Shanghai Jiao Tong University, said excessive reliance on AI companions among minors deserves particular attention because young people are more vulnerable to forming addictive attachments.

For older people living alone, however, she believes AI companions can help reduce loneliness and supplement, rather than replace, human relationships. Li argued that regulations should distinguish between different user groups rather than adopt a one-size-fits-all approach.

"What's important isn't whether AI will replace humans," Li said. "It's understanding which emotional needs AI can meet, and which should remain part of human-to-human relationships." ★

Kids and parents participate in an AI-themed study tour held in Wuhan, Hubei Province, August 21, 2025 (Photo by VCG)

AI Study Camps

Artificial Promises

AI-themed study tours are hugely popular, but experts warn parents not to fall for the hype that their kids can create the next DeepSeek in a few short days

By Meng Qian and Xu Ming

"Are there real children who have participated in an AI camp at Alibaba?" a netizen named Xiaosuda posted a question on lifestyle platform RedNote in May. The mother from Beijing was considering signing her son up to an AI study tour at Alibaba's headquarters, based in Hangzhou, Zhejiang Province, a popular program this summer. But the shortage of real feedback online made her hesitate. Under her post, many parents who were lured by the description in ads expressed the same confusion, saying they are waiting for follow-up information.

Chinese social platforms are flooded with ads for AI study camps for the summer vacation. In past summers, camps for English, sports and museums were the most popular, but now parents feel they must expose their children to AI education as early as possible. Participants, usually primary and

middle school students, visit universities and tech companies in big cities and learn how to use AI tools in trips usually lasting up to a week.

Bookings for AI-related study tours rose 370 percent this summer on travel provider Trip's platform, the company said.

Tutoring institutions, travel agencies, universities and tech companies are swarming into this niche. As competition intensifies, some agencies try to attract attention with flashy and overhyped ads that claim they will produce an AI genius in a few days, with slogans like "Start an entrepreneurial journey at 7" or "Cultivate the next Elon Musk."

The mushrooming of camps and the dizzying array of ads are already putting many parents on guard, who doubt whether the camps can deliver what they promise.

Keeping Linked

Zhang Lan, a parent from Shanxi Province, found she was lost in a sea of information when trying to find her 11-year-old son an AI camp. There are plenty of agencies and the courses vary a lot. Many of her son's classmates had already headed to cities like Beijing, Hangzhou and Hong Kong.

"The institutions are all over the place. Totally no idea how to pick. Please help me avoid the pitfalls," read her post on RedNote.

A 2025 survey by iiMedia, a data analysis platform, shows that 63 percent of interviewed consumers were willing to enroll their children in all types of study tours. The survey predicted that by 2028, technologies like augmented reality, virtual reality and AI will be widely integrated into study tours.

"AI study tour demand in the Shenzhen-Hong Kong market has continued to climb since the beginning of this year, and the number of AI tour groups has already jumped 20 to 30 percent compared to the same period last year," said Chen Chongjie from Greater Bay Area Hong Kong & Macao Talents Association who develops study tours. "Parents are obviously anxious about AI. They hope their children will grasp AI in five days or even master AI tools skillfully."

This year, tech companies including Alibaba, Unitree Robotics, AI developer DeepSeek and research institutions were top destinations for these tours. Universities with strong research capabilities like Tsinghua and Peking universities are popular choices.

AI camps usually involve touring tech company showrooms or university campuses, visiting science and space museums, and trying out basic AI tools like image and music generators or operating robot arms.

Zhu Ping, founder of a travel agent based in Nanjing, Jiangsu Province, told *China Youth Daily* in May that they added visits to tech companies to their study tours last summer vacation. Now AI-related camps account for over 80 percent of residential camps around Shanghai and Hangzhou, which involves universities like Shanghai Jiao Tong University and Zhejiang University and tech companies like Alibaba and robot company Shenhao Technology.

She said students joining the camps will not only visit companies but also have lessons and hands-on practice. At entertainment company Huaguoshan Cultural Media in Hangzhou, students can use AI to finish a painting or produce an animated short. They can also control the robots to shake hands or walk in tech companies' exhibition centers.

"This kind of hands-on experience is irreplaceable, no textbook or video can match it," Zhu said. "Once kids try it themselves, they get curious and start asking questions. Each evening, our mentors help them review the day's lessons and consolidate their learning."

More advanced camps are project-driven. One study tour run by Alibaba at their Hangzhou headquarters advertises that students will work there for six days and learn how to build a digital agent to run an e-commerce store on Taobao.

Some camps claim to use AI tools to turn children's ideas into reality while developing their entrepreneurial skills. In these camps, the children establish startup teams and use AI tools to design a product. They end by making a pitch to a panel of judges, representing investors.

Experts and netizens are skeptical about camps that promise quick results and instant results. They are not a panacea for parents who are anxious their child might be left behind in the new tech revolution.

One teacher who has taught teens for over a decade said many AI camps do not sell courses but market emotional solutions to parents. "Many camps use an eye-catching title to persuade parents, who are not able to judge their value," the teacher told *NewsChina* on condition of anonymity.

Uneven Quality

Besides big cities like Beijing and Shanghai, many areas in China are trying to catch up on the trend.

Yuan Bo, an internet engineer from Beijing, told *NewsChina* that AI-themed study tours are growing popular nationwide, from first-tier cities to remote areas like Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region and even county areas.

These popular camps are not cheap. Some AI camps in big cities like Beijing, Shanghai and Hangzhou cost 6,000 yuan (US$886), while tours to Hong Kong charge over 10,000 yuan (US$1,480). Overseas camps could cost 20,000-30,000 yuan (US$3,000-4,400) with destinations including universities in Singapore, Australia and the US. Project-themed camps are more expensive, reaching 10,000-30,000 (US$1,480-4,400) yuan.

Chen Chongjie noted that more

newcomers are flooding in. Many institutions that previously offered outdoor activities and math or English training have turned to AI, often buying services from third parties. These camps, though they have existing name recognition, have no AI background.

"Many institutions that don't even have proper travel licenses are running study tours, giving rise to various malpractices such as false advertising," Chen Chongjie said. He added that some AI-themed camps are even held in hotels, blurring the definition of a study tour.

Under current regulations, study tour providers must possess three licenses: a business license, a travel agency permit and proof of educational service capacity. Yet many entities offering AI study camps are nothing more than recently registered cultural media companies, or even temporary one-person operations.

Many parents complained online about the poor quality and value of AI camps. Some said that the visits to universities and internet companies are just rushed walkthroughs and photo ops.

Xiao Ping, whose 13-year-old son went on an AI-themed tour to Hangzhou in July, told *NewsChina* that it fell vastly short of expectations. The tour was advertised as a tour to Alibaba, but the activity was actually held in a place near the company. The children were taught to make cable-driven robotic arms and use AI to create mini-games. "I think their main purpose is promoting their follow-up courses that cost 35,000 yuan (US$5,170)," said the mother from Jiangxi Province.

Wang Meng, who has engaged in outdoor study tours for more than 10 years, designed a trip to Harbin Institute of Technology (HIT) this summer. The camp was very popular as she cooperated with a high-tech company, where the children visited its semiconductor lab and took AI-related courses.

On social media, there are many products claiming to be HIT-related. "Actually, many are offered by local travel agencies that just invoke the name AI. The entire camp is simply about visiting and taking photos," Wang said. "The trip is worth it as long as they take photos inside HIT."

Even relatively high-end entrepreneurship-themed AI camps are regarded as overhyped. Some parents describe the whole process as role play. The teachers are temporarily employed and the children memorize presentations to perform in front of "investors."

"The parents should ask themselves, 'What have they bought with 30,000 yuan (US$4,400), long-term capability or a beautifully packaged entrepreneurial experience?'" wrote one influencer who posts about AI on RedNote. Children can finish a prototype and demonstration in a few days with help from instructors, but it is hard to say that they really understand the technology, business and real customer demand.

Rational Attitude

Chen Chongjie believes the quality of instructors is the cornerstone of study tours. "The parents need to look carefully at whether the teachers are qualified and experienced, whether the team has a mature training system and how much professional knowledge they can deliver," Chen said.

However, there is a severe shortage of qualified AI instructors, particularly in second or third-tier cities, *NewsChina* learned. Many institutions use graduate students with little training, or people who have some basic programming knowledge. This is why children only learn how to use basic AI.

Ru Jiuer from WaytoAGI, an NGO and open-source community that compiles accessible AI knowledge, found that most people only use ByteDance's Doubao AI or DeepSeek as search tools and do not know how to develop child education on AI. "Many AI study tours need to let the kids realize their wild ideas can be brought to life," Ru said.

The AI study tour sector has yet to establish standardized curricula, instructor qualification criteria or assessment frameworks, leading to a market where the quality is wildly uneven, several interviewed analysts said.

"The AI study tour industry is far less institutionalized than established sectors such as coding education. Right now, it is still in its infancy and remains very much in an exploratory phase," Ru said.

Guo Yinrui, from a Hangzhou-based AI study tour brand, believes that AI study tours are still a new phenomenon, and in the end, it will be survival of the fittest. "Brands that invest in genuine content and quality will be the ones that last," she told *China Youth Daily*. "Those that just throw together a few site visits and tours without proposing any real value won't go far," she said.

She added that they tried to design in-depth, project-based study camps, but students at this age lack the work experience to fully grasp how AI is applied in real enterprises, so the market is quite limited. She said study tours must aim to be both professional and accessible to young learners.

Zhang Jie, co-founder of Daily Interactive, a data intelligence service provider, reminded parents to take a more rational attitude toward AI study tours in an interview with *China Youth Daily*.

"You can't expect a short tour to produce a dramatic leap in a child's capabilities. These programs are, at their core, experiential consumption. For today's kids, AI is not something foreign. It's a native companion that will naturally grow with them into their daily lives," Zhang noted. ★

Zhang Lan, Wang Meng and Xiao Ping are pseudonyms

Blind Vloggers

Seeing Differently

After a faked short-video by a visually impaired vlogger sparked online skepticism, other blind content creators say their work is vital to raising awareness of the disabled community

By Ni Wei

With her white cane falling from her grip, a visually impaired 24-year-old woman, surnamed Jiang, tumbled on the tactile paving when a motorcyclist rushed past her on the narrow sidewalk.

"What are you doing? Have you got no eyes?" the driver yelled.

"I'm walking on the tactile paving," Jiang replied angrily.

Jiang is a vlogger with more than a million followers and goes by the online name Huggy Blind Bunny. She made the video to draw attention to rude and unfair treatment of visually impaired people when they are out walking and released it in early May.

However, on May 16, a few days after the video had gone viral, it was revealed the video was staged and had not been marked as such, according to Chinese law on online content. Sympathy for Jiang evaporated, and police took her and the bike rider, identified as a 26-year-old man surnamed Liu, in for questioning for possible future criminal charges. Jiang's account was banned.

Although people riding fast ebikes on pedestrian walkways and blocking sidewalks and tactile paving is a huge problem in China for all pedestrians, this staged video was the wrong way to draw attention to the issue.

According to the Law on Public Security and Notice on Strengthening the Administration of Self-Media issued in 2023, any unmarked staged videos which caused public outcry should attract penalties for the severe consequence it has caused. The video was reported by a number of online viewers who were skeptical about the authenticity of the scene.

The incident created a ripple effect within the online community of visually impaired vloggers, who have been documenting their lives, including walking

with a guide dog or traveling by high-speed rail and plane. Many videos were recommended by short-video platforms, like Douyin or Bilibili, as first-person accounts detailing what life is like for them.

But Jiang's incident sparked immense skepticism over these vlogs' genuineness, with viewers less inclined to be sympathetic.

"Previously, viewers were curious about how we live. Now they immediately question the truth of our vlogs," a popular blind vlogger, whose online name is Xia Guo, told *NewsChina*.

Fact vs Fabrication

This belief that content might be staged is seen in the comments below Xia's latest videos.

Comments posted under Xia's videos in the days after Jiang's controversial video included people asking if Xia was "truly blind," and how could Xia make their own videos without a team helping.

"What she [Jiang] challenged is not our traffic, but rather the ethical bottom line," Xia said. "If you shatter the trust, you never get it back. This staged video drained our public sympathy, so it's had a devastating social impact."

Xia is not the only one who has seen skeptical comments under posts.

"When you have to confront people who question the ethics of visually impaired vloggers like me, I can't respond other than to uphold my own integrity," a vlogger known as Ju Zi online, told *NewsChina*.

From Yinchuan, capital of Northwest China's Ningxia Hui Autonomous Region, Ju has 660,000 followers on Douyin.

In 2023, the Notice on Strengthening the Administration of Self-Media issued by the Cyberspace Administration of China stipulated that self-created content should not fabricate news, quote out of context, distort facts or spread unauthentic information with manipulative clipping and editing. Fictional and staged content should be clearly labeled as such.

A screenshot from blind vlogger Xia Guo's video of his guide dog's first flight (Photo courtesy of the interviewee)

Weng Zhihao, associate professor with the School of Journalism at Fudan University in Shanghai, told *NewsChina* that in some cases the creator can still be held liable for misleading content, even if it is marked as fictional. The fundamental principle is that short videos should not misguide the public.

"People scroll through posts on short video platforms so quickly they barely register if content is falsified, and not many viewers pay attention to any follow-up," Weng said. This includes whether videos have later been taken down for violations of the law.

"It's particularly important that creators shouldn't quote partially or piece together a video on critical agendas, such as education, politics, gender issues and social fairness," Weng said.

But the scrutiny may sometimes contradict with the pursuit of traffic.

According to Xia, to generate steady traffic, short videos by visually impaired people are often stereotyped with tags such as "first-person perspective of the blind," "guide dogs," "a blind person's first flight" and "abilities transcending eyesight."

Saturated Market

Multi-channel networks (MCN), brokers that promote vloggers to platforms and advertisers, have seen the allure of this content.

An anonymous MCN insider posted online that with his operations, the number of followers of two visually impaired vloggers surged from zero to over one million each.

In the wake of Jiang's incident, a former MCN staff member who spoke to *NewsChina* on condition of anonymity said the content arena for visually impaired vloggers is saturated. Anyone who wants to stand out must buy traffic and post staged videos.

Xia agrees. "Viewers have watched all the videos we think we can film. They may feel it's fresh the first time they watch, but they'll get bored by the 100th." Getting views then means sharing misery, conflicts or extreme circumstances, he said.

Xia, an undergraduate of the School of Special Education, Changchun University, Changchun, Jilin Province, started posting videos in 2021. His first hit was a 13.5-minute video he titled "The daily life of a blind university student-having a good meal, despite small mishaps" in 2024. It showed him navigating his way into the cafeteria despite bumping into obstacles. It was viewed more than 29 million times and won him the Best Annual Work Award from Bilibili in January 2025.

But it is getting harder. "I work hard to think of catchy titles for my videos,

such as 'blind but not bland' or 'China in the eyes of a blind person.' If you ask me what the best way [to gain popularity] is, I'd say it's still very much trial and error, and I don't really have a solution," Xia said. He paid platforms to promote his content, but there was no improvement. Now he feels traffic for visually impaired vloggers has peaked and their popularity is waning.

According to Weng, new entrants to platforms have no choice but to post much more frequently to have any hope of competing with established creators.

"They have two options, to stimulate the hot topics or what we call 'riding the trend,' or to explore creative topics," the scholar said. "Obviously, the latter isn't suitable for most, because it is much more costly and risky," he said. Gambling on creativity might fail in terms of attracting followers or views.

With 450,000 followers on Bilibili, Xia said he edits and shoots all his content.

When he rose to fame, several MCN companies reached out. Xia said these companies have two basic models. The first is one in which they offer full or partial services. Full service means taking all responsibility for dealing with brand sponsors, and the MCN takes a 30 percent cut of the profits. Partial service involves the MCN attracting brand sponsors but leaving creators with all the profits.

Xia partnered with a partial-service MCN for a few months. But after it failed to bring in sponsors, he ended the cooperation, deciding to go it alone.

The other MCN model is similar to an incubator, aiming to catapult rookies to prominence. Creators are treated like full-time employees and should submit 80 to 90 percent of their revenue to the MCN. But Xia has never been approached by this type of MCN, probably because he was already an influential creator.

Ju also declined to partner with an MCN, saying "as a simple vlogger, I've never desired to be a top influencer."

Unexpected Blow-up

"Annoying," Xia complained in his award-winning cafeteria video after he knocked into a metal gate. Comments were sympathetic, and he soon got millions of views.

"I was stunned, I just felt like an ark sailing amid torrents of traffic," he said.

But some viewers were still skeptical about who really produced Xia's videos, and it took time to convince them he was the only creator.

Other than his sports cam, Xia uses Reaper, a cross-platform digital audio workstation which has basic video editing functions.

At first, he spent much more time editing than filming because he could only make the video by sound. But now, it is a lot quicker, partly because his skills have improved, and partly because of AI tools he uses, especially for subtitles.

If Xia's success is proof of concept, Ju's popularity further confirms it.

Ju never thought her content would become so popular. Highlighting the utility of tactile paving and showing a journey in a new energy vehicle to experience autonomous driving, she said people have learned not to obstruct tactile paving and how not to "other" people who are different.

When people were confused about her interest in driving, Ju said: "When autonomous driving techniques are really developed well in future, I hope visually-impaired people will be able to drive. With hopes and expectations, lives can always be better."

She emphasized all her videos are made in collaboration with her husband and none of the clips are staged or manipulated.

Serious Message

Putting on makeup with the help of a screen read app, Ju heads to a supermarket after a yoga class, accompanied by her guide dog. With her vlog series on her daily life, viewers realized that blind people are just like them.

"We can make ourselves look pretty. But, can you imagine some blind people have been shut-ins for 20 years," Ju said. She said her videos are produced not only for her to be seen, but also for more visually impaired people to have the courage to go out too.

Through their vlogs, more people can understand blind people have different personalities and live in great diversity, Ju said. This goes beyond stereotyped images of blind people only doing jobs like massage therapy, or who have trouble walking along blocked streets.

China has about 85 million people living with disabilities, approximately one in 16 people, revealed Wang Jinhua, director-general of the Department of Social Affairs, the Ministry of Civil Affairs, at a press conference in Beijing on September 23, 2024.

By November 2022, 14.1 million videos covering a wide range of areas, such as fruit picking, playing the flute and giving massages, had been released on Douyin by people living with disabilities, Douyin said on December 2, 2022, a day ahead of the International Day of Persons with Disabilities.

"The internet has enabled more and more marginalized groups to become the center of attention or gain overnight prominence. Meanwhile, their content creation on platforms has brought them needed economic independence. This is too important to be drowned out by a few who have made mistakes in their conduct," Weng said.

"Content creation has granted a bigger say for people living with disabilities or other vulnerabilities. These groups can get straight to the heart of public discourse and tell their own history," he added.

Despite the recent flurry of suspicions, Xia refuses to stop. "Without voices from social media being heard, few realize they have actually lived in this world," he said.★

Relationship Coaches

Man Handling

A slew of self-anointed relationship gurus is selling Chinese women strategies to navigate love, marriage and financial security, promising that intimacy can be managed like a problem with the right skills

By Zhao Xibei, Fang Yuan and Xu Ming

AI-generated image (Photo by Adan)

After more than two years together, Wang Wei felt her boyfriend was becoming increasingly distant.

A successful businessman, he had been supporting her financially and even helped her open a beauty salon. Now she was worried that he might be interested in someone else and wanted to save the relationship.

She then thought of an influencer she followed, Sister Mu. Mu had appeared on a relationship-focused reality show for Tianjin TV in 2025, where she offered advice to troubled couples.

In her online clips, Mu talks about relationship fixes, as well as tips on finding what she calls a "high-value" man. One of her courses explains the process in 11 videos.

Wang first reached out over social media in early 2026. She was invited into a WeChat group, where she was told Mu no longer takes on individual cases. Instead, they offered to pair Wang with a coach suited to her needs.

Though disappointed, Wang handed over 100 yuan (US$15) for an initial consultation. The first thing the coach asked for was Wang's chat history with her boyfriend.

Relationship coaching marketed to women like Wang on social media is creating multi-million-yuan fortunes. The market ranges from livestream sessions costing more than 1,000 yuan (US$148) to intensive one-on-one packages or offline training running tens of thousands of yuan.

Some coaches specifically target women seeking to "marry up," teaching them how to attract desirable men through appearance, feminine charm and sexual appeal. Others advise women already in relationships on how to increase their influence and leverage, especially when it comes to money. Often, the men at the center of these consultations have no idea they are taking place.

Though more than a decade old, the industry is facing increasing scrutiny from the public, experts and authorities. Some of its most prominent figures have faced social media bans following new regulations. Released last year, they require platforms to remove content from unqualified counselors that "spreads misguided ideas" about sexual health, especially

posts containing sexually suggestive or veiled messages.

But the bans did not eliminate demand. Some influencers took their businesses into private WeChat groups and offline, while less prominent coaches like Mu have moved in to fill the gap.

Between the Lines

Coaches claim chat histories offer a candid window into the relationship. They analyze conversations to assess the couple's personalities and interactions, as well as what kind of relationship they want.

When Wang complained that her boyfriend was ignoring her emotional needs, the coach told her to stop "begging for hugs and comfort."

"He invested in your shops, which means he wants a long-term relationship with you," the coach said. "Since he's a businessman, date like a businesswoman rather than a college girl. Don't dump your negative emotions and anxiety on him."

The coach suggested that Wang post photos of herself meeting business partners and expanding her network. "You need to let him know you are making progress and can make money, not just that you are a spendthrift," she said, adding that Wang should not focus exclusively on one man.

When *NewsChina* followed up with Wang in August, she declined to comment on whether the advice had worked for her. But their sessions offer a glimpse into these coaches' main selling point – when an intimate relationship becomes rocky, it can be managed through strategies and actionable advice, putting the outcome within a woman's control.

'Sexual Intelligence'

Le Chuanqu, a high-profile relationship coach known to her followers as Big Woman Ququ, adheres to this philosophy with a cynical fundamentalism, one that somewhat mirrors the hyper chauvinist views of influencers in the Manosphere.

The former singer turned relationship advisor portrays dating, marriage and even childbirth as mere tools for climbing the social ladder. An oft-repeated mantra in her courses is "the nature of relationships is exchanging value."

Lin Xiaozhe, a former member of Le's community, told *NewsChina* that her courses focus on how to take the lead in a relationship, develop it more quickly and determine whether a man is worth pursuing.

Le earns mainly through livestreams, courses and her online community, which has generated more than 100 million yuan (US$14.8m), with top-tier members paying nearly 200,000 yuan (US$29,540) to join, according to news outlet chengdu.cn.

She was banned from major online platforms like Sina Weibo in December 2023 for promoting what was described as "unhealthy relationship values." In April 2025, Le was penalized 7.58 million yuan (US$1.12m) for tax evasion, according to Shanghai tax authorities.

However, her business continues through more private channels. Le now runs exclusive WeChat groups and her own monthly subscription app for 199 yuan (US$30).

Zhou Yuan takes a more overtly sexual approach. Now in her 40s, Zhou used to work in a bank and operated a beauty clinic before becoming China's most controversial relationship coach.

During a three-day training session held by her "Sexual Intelligence Academy" in April, *NewsChina* learned that Zhou taught participants how to become an "enchanting Siren," including detailed instruction on clothing choices, makeup, how to walk and flirtatious touching, even encouraging her students to touch her and one another on the breasts, hips and waist to demonstrate.

Her courses are marketed as ways to "save marriages."

Representatives of the Academy told news platform Blue Whale Finance it had attracted more than 100,000 learners since it was established in 2018, raking in more than 24 million yuan (US$3.6m) in revenue based on listed prices and enrollment figures.

In January, Zhou's operations were the center of an investigation by market supervision authorities in Changsha, Hunan Province. Like Le, Zhou was banned from social media platforms for "spreading vulgar and suggestive content," which included teaching how to seduce men through body language. Her most viral technique is the "X-shaped" posture, where a woman faces her torso in one direction, turns her head the opposite way, and speaks in a sultry tone.

But Zhou managed to direct followers to offline courses held in inconspicuous locations.

Many relationship coaches develop videos and livestreams into channels to promote product lines, from books and cosmetics to sex toys. Some offer access to chat groups of "high-value men" or hold online matchmaking events.

Wang Xin, an associate professor at Shandong University who has studied relationship influencers, said the industry has evolved significantly over the past decade.

"Ayawawa, a relationship coach who was popular 10 years ago, focused on keeping a man, which was more defensive and less aggressive," Wang said. "Ququ, however, emphasizes upward mobility, 'securing the target' and 'cashing in.' Zhou Yuan adopts a more self-focused and performative persona, subtly packaging her aggressiveness in a gentler form."

"But they are no different in nature," Wang said. "Their strategies are becoming increasingly packaged and easier to implement."

Quick Fixes

Not all women buying these courses are looking to land a rich husband. Zhong Ying, a former student of Zhou Yuan's, told *Jiemian News* that many participants enrolled because they wanted to improve their intimate relationships. Some learners said Zhou's video courses provide sex education they did not receive at school.

Chen Feifei, who attended Zhou Yuan's offline course twice, told *NewsChina* she joined to feel better about her "stagnant" marriage. Meeting her husband on a blind date, Chen said the two had never developed a deep connection and had drifted apart emotionally.

She said the three-day course, which taught relationship skills while providing moral support, better equipped her to work on her marriage.

Most of Zhou's offline students are married women in their 30s and 40s. Xue Jing, an expert on mass culture at Tsinghua University, describes many of them as "knowing fools."

"They don't believe the courses can bring back happiness," Xue said. "Instead, they want to make themselves tolerate the marriage and keep their lives on track."

That desire for something practical may be part of the appeal. Li Songwei, a counselor with a PhD in psychology from Peking University, noted that in the era of social media, people increasingly believe that all problems have a hack or shortcut.

"Online paid knowledge products are, by nature, an attempt to address people's feelings of losing control over their lives, whether in career planning or raising high-achieving children. They at least cater to people's expectations that problems can be solved. It is the same with intimate relationship courses," Li said.

Li said people increasingly treat intimate relationships as mathematical problems rather than allowing themselves to experience the uncertainty of intimacy.

"The idea that it's better to find a rich husband than to build a career is not new," Li said. "What has changed in recent years is that marrying up is increasingly presented as something achievable through training and a series of strategies."

"Compared with more time-consuming and effort-intensive approaches such as counseling, skill-based learning tends to promise faster results, which is precisely why it has gained traction among women eager to improve their romantic relationships," said Wang Zhoulan, a therapist based in Chengdu, Sichuan Province.

'Illusion of Control'

While similar courses exist for men, such as by pickup artist Langji, who was forced to shut down his operations in 2018 and wiped from the Chinese internet a year later, relationship courses in China mainly target women, interviewed analysts said. "Although women's social status has improved significantly, at least for many women, marriage still directly determines their material circumstances to a considerable extent," Wang Xin said.

But the strategies being sold to women have changed. A decade ago, relationship courses often taught women to endure difficulties and make concessions to preserve their marriages. Today, many teach women how to manage their relationship and gain more sway in it.

Though seemingly opposites, Wang Xin believes both approaches share the same underlying logic. "They are based on the assumption that only when men are satisfied can women gain a sense of security," she said. "The difference lies only in the strategies used to achieve that goal."

The newer approach can sound more empowering. Some influencers present their methods as a way for women to become more confident, independent and capable of controlling their own lives. "This sounds encouraging to women trapped in difficult situations and can easily elevate their emotions," Wang Xin said.

But critics question where that empowerment ultimately leads. Therapist Wang Zhoulan told *Jiemian News* in February that Zhou Yuan's courses "teach women how to achieve self-improvement through appearance, but their ultimate goal remains pleasing men, making self-improvement merely a tool to reach that goal."

Xue Jing agreed that women taught to use sexual appeal to manipulate men may only gain a false sense of control. "Their sense of worth is built on whether their value is recognized by their male partners," she said.

Li said he did not want to judge such practices on a moral level, but he questioned whether it was realistic to expect formulas and strategies to provide control over life.

"They may only create an illusion of control," he said.

Wang Xin believes they reflect women's anxiety surrounding intimate relationships and deeper structural problems in society.

She said that women in China today continue to bear certain costs of social development, including the burdens of childbirth, unequal treatment in the workplace and disparities in property rights. For a considerable number of women, marriage remains closely tied to their lives, particularly their economic circumstances.

"It is inappropriate to morally judge these learners with contempt," Xue added. "Instead, we should understand the fears behind their choices. Only then can we find common ground and help people rediscover genuine love and respect." ★

Wang Wei, Lin Xiaozhe, Zhong Ying and Chen Feifei are pseudonyms

A crowd views a large 3D-printed model in the showroom of Bambu Lab's flagship store, Shenzhen, Guangdong Province, October, 2025 (Photo by VCG)

Printing Pressure

Demand for household 3D printers relies on improvements in usability and software, or they risk becoming the next fad

By Shi Hanxu and Xie Ying

The 3D printer has sat silently on Lin Ming's desk for three months.

Encouraged by seemingly endless short videos on lifestyle platform RedNote about 3D printing, where creators demonstrated how to make custom storage boxes and belt buckles, or boasted of six-figure monthly incomes from selling printed handicrafts, Li took the plunge, buying one for over 1,000 yuan (US$148).

"It sounded amazing to turn any random idea into a tangible object," Li said, adding he had read claims that 3D printers were "plug-and-play game changers."

For the first two weeks, Li scoured online pattern libraries, printing trinkets of all shapes and sizes. But gradually, the printing shrank to weekend sessions, until the machine sat untouched for weeks, only used when a sudden DIY need popped up.

Opinions on their utility for amateur users is split. Some hail them as all-powerful creation tools, while others dismiss them as useless electronic clutter, yet another item that is gathering dust.

Niche to Mass Market

A 3D printer creates solid objects layer by layer by melting plastic filament and extruding it onto a heated bed based on digital model blueprints. It builds items from bottom to top instead of cutting materials away like traditional manufacturing machines. They are used at industrial levels, as well as for hobbyists.

Five years ago, consumer 3D printers were a niche product. "Printers at that time were not a finished product," Chen Bo, co-founder of 3D printer manufacturer Shenzhen Elegoo Technology, told *NewsChina*. Buyers had to assemble the printer and make complicated adjustments before printing, as well as calibrate fiddly print settings and convert 3D digital models into a printable instruction for the layers.

These complicated and time-consuming procedures deterred many potential amateur users.

The turning point came in 2022 when Bambu Lab, a Chinese 3D printer maker in Shenzhen, Guangdong Province, debuted its groundbreaking X1 series desktop printer. Equipped with integrated multi-sensor arrays, motion control algorithms and automatic compensation mechanisms, it lowered operational barriers and became an instant crowdfunding hit on Kickstarter.

This launch drove the Chinese 3D printer industry to shift their focus to user-friendliness. Competitors including Anycubic, Creality and Elegoo quickly followed, installing their new models with AI laser range-finders, built-in monitoring cameras and fully automatic bed leveling technology – adjusting nozzles to create a perfect first layer. "This marked the first time 3D printers truly realized the 'unbox and print' promise," Chen said.

The biggest beneficiaries were print speed and multi-color output. Early consumer 3D printers only reached several dozens of millimeters per second, while new models hit 500 to 600 millimeters per second. "It took 10 hours to print a palm-sized toy before, but now it's only one hour," Ju Zheng, Creality's marketing director, told *NewsChina*.

Meanwhile, multi-color printing, once reserved for premium high-end equipment, has trickled down to entry-level products. Some modular printers can load up to 16 different colored filaments and automatically print multi-color models.

AI has also made printers far more autonomous. Built-in AI cameras automatically detect common printing failures such as nozzle clogging or filament stringing, where thin plastic threads remain between printed parts. The system can identify foreign objects left on the print plate like scissors and pause operations.

"Previously, users were playing with printers, but now they can focus on the printing," a Bambu Lab manager who did not reveal his name told *NewsChina*.

As usability improved, prices plunged. Five years ago, a mid-size mainstream printer cost at least 3,000 yuan (US$450), and a premium CoreXY model cost close to 10,000 yuan (US$1,500). Today, entry-level machines from all major brands fall into the 1,000-3000 yuan (US$150-450) bracket.

The cost of printing materials also declined. PLA (polylactic acid) filament, the most widely used desktop printing material, had cost 200 yuan (US$30) per roll, but now a spool costs under 100 yuan (US$15). Printing a small daily product like a wall hook, a phone holder or a miniature ornament costs a few yuan in materials.

Bambu Lab found that users are no longer mostly engineers and model hobbyists, but now include craft lovers, lifestyle creators and ordinary families, with social media feeds flooded with examples of useful printed products.

According to Chen Yixin, managing director at China Insights Consultancy (CIC), a Shanghai-based industry analyst, the global consumer 3D printing market in 2025 reached a gross merchandise volume of US$6 billion. It is estimated to rise to US$27.2 billion by 2030, representing a compound annual growth rate exceeding 35 percent.

According to a report by RedNote released at the end of 2025, 3D printers were among the top 10 most searched for products, with requests surging by 238 percent and connected topics viewed over 1.65 billion times.

In September 2025, China's Ministry of Commerce and other agencies issued a document that for the first time listed consumer 3D printers as a key digital product which attracts a State consumption subsidy for intelligent products.

"The industry is striding from the niche enthusiast community to a mainstream consumer market," Zhu Yuanyuan, a senior analyst at Runto Technology, a technology industry analysis firm based in Beijing, told *NewsChina*.

'Three-Month' Curse

Yet despite the thriving market, many users find they have little use for their printers. A search on second-hand marketplace Xianyu reveals hundreds of barely used or brand-new 3D printers offered at steep discounts. Many say they are good as new. On both RedNote and Xianyu, many people post that they have no idea what to print, attracting thousands of sympathetic comments from disillusioned owners.

According to an April 2026 survey of 3,000 users conducted by e-commerce platform JD.com, Q1 sales of 3D printers, accessories and materials grew by about 100 percent year-on-year, but 58.2 percent of surveyed users said they used the machine to print less than five items. Only 13 percent of users printed more than 20 items.

Elegoo's backend data shows that the first month after delivery marked the peak period for use, with nearly all buyers printing daily. Just three months later, the user group was heavily segmented. "Those who often print after three months stay long-term active users. If they don't use it much after three

months, then it's probably going to be switched off forever," Chen Bo said.

The main reason is the high barrier to original 3D modeling. Although new versions streamline the physical printing workflow and provide online pattern libraries with ready-to-print models, these templates cannot match every user's personalized needs. "Model libraries are like a music app packed with songs, but they aren't tailored just to your taste," Chen said.

If users want a custom item, they need to learn complex 3D modeling software, or pay freelance designers. Most amateur users just give up.

Beijinger Wang Jin told *NewsChina* that she sent her primary school-age son to an activity camp for 3D-printing, but found that most children needed teachers to help them, or they could not turn their drawings into 3D products like the camp advertised.

Wang said she refused to buy a home 3D-printer after that. "None of my family knows about modeling and I'm sure that the machine wouldn't be used. It's just a waste of money," she said.

Even if the modeling issue is solved, amateur users face another question: what to print?

Lin Mengjie, a young woman in Chengdu, Sichuan Province, bought a second-hand 3D printer last year. She started by printing a cat litter scoop, wall hooks and household items, and uses them every day. Now she only uses her printer two or three times a month. "I've printed everything I need, and now I don't know what to print next," she said.

Li Jing, the mother of a fourth grader in Beijing, told *NewsChina* that her son mainly uses the printer to make toys to sell to classmates. "There's no room at home for all these toys," she said.

Wang told *NewsChina* that her son bought several cheap 3D toys, but they were only fun for a couple of days. "I don't find those toys are well made. They end up in the trash," she said.

Chen Bo observed that people overseas use 3D printers more often and for longer periods than Chinese users. Elegoo's backend data shows that domestic users mostly operate printers on weekends and holidays with sporadic evening sessions on workdays, while overseas buyers run machines steadily on weekday afternoons with longer single print jobs and evenly distributed weekly usage.

A child tries on a 3D-printed helmet at the Southwest International Model & Gaming Expo China, Kunming, Yunnan Province, April 2026 (Photo by VCG)

Experts said the difference is down to Western countries' well-established DIY and garage workshop cultures, where people are accustomed to repairing, renovating and fabricating household goods themselves, making 3D printing a natural extension of their daily lifestyle. Higher labor costs also make DIY more attractive.

In China, the well-developed logistics system and huge manufacturing sector makes buying household accessories cheap and efficient.

"When Chinese consumers find a broken household item, their first response is to order a replacement online, not print one at home," the anonymous Bambu Lab manager said.

AI Boost?

But even if the printers are not in regular use, it does not mean false market demand. According to the JD.com report, over 70 percent of those surveyed said they were interested in 3D printing. Data from Nanjixiong, a social media providing 3D printing industrial information, shows that China's domestic 3D printing industry recorded 100 to 118 rounds of financing last year, covering 81 to 95 enterprises with total funding approaching 10 billion yuan (US$1.5b), double the figure in 2024.

Chen Yixin told *NewsChina* that besides the machines themselves, investors value the consistent consumption of materials and the software ecology promoted by long-term active users and their interactions. He predicts that uptake will grow along with their use as AI technologies will help people design their own models.

But the Bambu Lab manager noted that it will take a long time before consumer 3D printers become as easy to use as a microwave, because its usability is connected to complicated processes, the physical features of materials and post-processing.

Chen Bo believes that full color printing will create a new surge in demand. "Once this technology matures, 3D printed objects will no longer be defined by shape, but by delicate color with refined textures nearly identical to finished physical products. Widespread full-color printing may trigger exponential user expansion," he said.

Ju Zheng believes that besides hardware, attracting and keeping 3D printer users will depend on usability, the creator community and an ecosystem of products and services. This includes making it easy for users to find a suitable model to print, access software that solves common problems and share their products with a community to spur creativity.

"When you're able to deliver exactly what you imagine as simply as taking a photo, it will only be a matter of time before it reaches every family," Zhu Yuanyuan said. ★

Li Ming and Lin Mengjie are pseudonyms

Non-compete Deals

Blocking the Exit

New laws take aim at the misuse of employee non-compete deals, which experts and judges say is restricting labor flows and innovation

By Li Mingzi and Wang Yan

In early June 2026, electric vehicle maker XPeng Motors sparked industry-wide debate by filing labor arbitration seeking nearly 10 million yuan (US$1.48m) from a former senior R&D engineer for breach of a non-compete clause.

XPeng honored its contractual obligations by paying monthly non-compete compensation in full and on schedule after the employee resigned. Still, the engineer from its General Intelligence & Robotics Center, who held restricted stock, quickly took an identical R&D role at a direct rival.

XPeng uncovered the breach during a companywide compliance audit of ex-staff. It filed an arbitration claim, demanding immediate resignation from the rival and completion of the remaining non-compete term, full refund of all non-compete payouts, repayment of gains from selling XPeng restricted shares and substantial contractual liquidated damages, totaling almost 10 million yuan (US$1.48m).

Since the case began, XPeng issued commercial secret compliance rules to its staff on August 7, covering areas in its supply chain and employment cycle, from entering to terminating labor contracts, guancha.cn reported.

The case stands out for its unusual demand to recoup stock proceeds, underscoring XPeng's tough stance on protecting core tech and IP amid cutthroat competition in China's new energy vehicle sector. The case is not yet resolved.

"Multi-million-yuan non-compete claims and stock-profit recovery remedies are now widespread," Cui Can, an attorney at Chengdu-based Tahota Law Firm told *NewsChina*. He noted that such steep demands reflect the unprecedentedly high market value for core technical talent amid fierce rivalry in the high-tech sector.

Well before XPeng's filing, high-stakes non-compete disputes proliferated across the new energy vehicle, internet, semiconductor and autonomous driving sectors. Conflicts fall into two camps: firms suing breaching staff, and workers challenging unfair, overbroad non-compete clauses.

Excessive Penalty

A non-compete agreement bars former employees from competing against their ex-employer for a set term, safeguarding trade secrets and proprietary data. It is supposed to preserve corporate market standing.

Cui said that according to his experience, the new energy industry only maintains a technical edge for around a year. Amid this breakneck competition, poaching entire rival teams beats doing internal R&D.

Many recruiters now offer loopholes to bypass non-compete clauses. A Hangzhou Qiantang District Court case disclosed in December 2025 highlighted a biotech researcher surnamed Pan, who joined a competitor under his spouse's identity with pay, tax filings and even patents registered in his partner's name.

In April, Hangzhou Intermediate People's Court released its 2021-2025 Labor Dispute Trial White Paper. High-tech enterprise litigation jumped from under 25 percent of all labor cases in 2021 to over half by 2025. Judicial assistant Zhong Guowei told *NewsChina* that non-compete rules pose one of the courts' trickiest litigation challenges.

Cui has witnessed a surge in corporate damage claims. While companies once sought 30,000 to 50,000 yuan (US$4,421-7,400) in compensation, they now routinely demand three to five million yuan (US$444,600-741,100). Claimants commonly pursue damages equal to three to five times the employee's annual salary, sometimes up to tenfold. "Major tech firms are systematically enforcing and countering non-compete rules. Their goals extend beyond safeguarding trade secrets, and they aim to drive up the costs of their rivals of poaching talent," Cui said.

Damage awards for non-compete breaches are even higher in cutting-edge high-tech sectors including AI and robotics, as they compete over the same staff. "Cutthroat industry competition lies at the root of distorted non-compete practices," Cui said. He recalled that litigation over non-compete restrictions in the internet industry exploded in 2024.

Data released by Beijing No.1 Intermediate People's Court in July 2025 corroborates this trend. Between 2020 and June 2025, the court concluded 432 labor dispute cases involving non-compete restrictions, representing a 104.73 percent jump compared with the 2014-2019 period. According to a court press release, these cases reflect prominent traits: highly mobile talent pools, obvious regional industrial clusters and a concentration of disputes in high-tech industries.

Pictured is the CIMC Industry City for digital technology, Dongguan, Guangdong Province, November 29, 2024 (Photo by VCG)

Overly Broad Restriction

A prevailing trend is that companies increasingly impose noncompete agreements on employees who never had access to trade secrets.

Liang Xu, a junior algorithm engineer, had worked at his new company for more than six months when he received an arbitration summons by email. His former automotive employer sued him for 1.8 million yuan (US$270,000) in non-compete-related damages, covering repayment of compensation, economic losses and legal fees. "That sum was at least three times my annual salary there. I was utterly shocked," Liang said.

Signing the non-compete contract was compulsory. His old company had an extremely demanding culture, which took a toll on his health. When he resigned, management gave him a non-compete deal that vastly expanded restricted industries to robotics, semiconductors and other fields, alongside a blacklist of nearly 200 companies. "It effectively barred me from working anywhere in the entire sector," Liang told *NewsChina*.

Cui Can said that major technology groups draft non-compete terms covering nearly all competitors and subsidiaries, resulting in unreasonably broad restrictions. In one recent case he litigated, the employer's list of restricted businesses spanned five full pages and named 436 separate entities.

Junior staff face severe financial strain from these rules. Standard two-year non-compete payouts are rarely enough to cover living expenses without industry employment. At his previous auto firm, Liang earned 50,000 yuan (US$7,400) per month, yet his post-resignation non-compete compensation was 10,000 yuan (US$1,500) monthly. After covering his mortgage and car loan repayments, little remained.

Non-compete constraints create cascading disadvantages that worsen during job searches. A senior human resources specialist with recruitment experience at multiple large tech firms told *NewsChina* that any serious non-compete violation record leads to automatic rejection.

Yang Jun, a former administrative employee at a big technology enterprise, resigned in early 2025 for personal reasons and moved back to his home in southern China. Half a year into his new local role, he unexpectedly received a court summons. His prior employer demanded over 1 million yuan (US$147,640), alleging a breach of non-compete duties.

"I still can't identify any trade secrets I was entrusted with," Yang told *NewsChina*. He sought help from his current company's HR and legal departments, which both expressed astonishment as they had never seen non-compete enforcement pursued against such a low-ranking staff member. He ended up paying his old firm a small amount in compensation.

Setting Hurdles

A 2025 August report in the *Legal Daily* referenced a 2023 study by Wuhan University law professor Yu Shuhong, which analyzed 454 non-compete judgments and found over 70 percent of respondents held entry-level positions such as salespeople, trainers, security guards, janitors and receptionists.

Shen Jianfeng, a professor at the Central University of Finance and Economics in Beijing, told the *Legal Daily* that non-compete clauses should function as a protective "firewall" for trade secrets rather than a barrier to talent mobility. Their fundamental purpose is to prevent confidential information leaks, not block job switching.

"Against a backdrop of brutal industry competition, non-compete

clauses have turned into an inexpensive lever for businesses to limit employee departures, coerce existing staff and even earn income," Cui said. These sweeping cross-industry bans rarely restrain senior managers who actually hold trade secrets. In these cases, new employers will cover the refund of their non-compete compensation if they are sued, and arrange remote work so they are not tracked.

The majority of Cui's clients are workers in their 20s and 30s with hardly any exposure to confidential corporate data, yet they face the heaviest damage claims. A second troubling shift is the proliferation of non-compete provisions beyond the internet space, where supermarkets, pharmaceutical enterprises and livestream influencers are subject to such terms. "Numerous listed companies that never relied on non-compete restrictions have begun rolling them out," he said.

Cui has established an advocacy coalition to counter the abuse of non-compete agreements, which has over 3,000 members across the internet, new energy, automotive and other sectors. He acknowledges that non-compete contracts serve a valid legal purpose in protecting trade secrets. Still, intensifying corporate rivalry has distorted them into a low-cost tactic for large corporations to block talent mobility. The single biggest worry shared by the coalition's members is whether they retain the freedom to change careers.

"Large technology groups now maintain specialized teams solely tasked with non-compete enforcement, backed by formal accountability systems," Cui said. They identify employees' next employers, contract third parties to gather evidence and assign attorneys. Certain companies' non-compete enforcement divisions bring in hundreds of millions of yuan annually.

Liang Xu endured an aggressive investigation. His former company sent him tracked mail to create tangible evidence that he was employed at a competitor, even though Liang's new employer had rented an off-site office space. Private investigators posed as prospective renters to extract information from the landlord. Ahead of the March court hearing, Liang's former employer voluntarily offered him 500,000 yuan (US$73,840) to settle. The company's HR manager privately told Liang he was not suspected of leaking any trade secrets, instead the firm had faced rampant staff departures and wanted to punish him to deter other employees from leaving.

Companies on both sides of employment relationships are aggressively enforcing non-compete clauses while simultaneously launching countermeasures against these restrictive agreements. "No party wins in this dynamic," Cui said.

Striking a Balance

In June 2025, the Supreme People's Court (SPC) highlighted a widely publicized labor dispute between a Nanjing restaurant and a chef surnamed Liu. The restaurant forced Liu to sign a non-compete deal barring him from all catering work for two years post-resignation, with contractual penalties ranging from 5,000 to 10,000 yuan (US$740-1,500).

But the Nanjing court ruled in Liu's favor, holding that ordinary kitchen staff without knowledge of proprietary recipes or core business strategies cannot be bound by such contracts, even if they did sign them. The restaurant failed to prove Liu had any of these.

In August 2025, the SPC released a revised Judicial Interpretation on Labor Disputes. The document states non-compete clauses are unenforceable against employees who never accessed trade secrets or IP-related confidential materials, regardless of signed paperwork. The updated judicial rules took effect on September 1, 2025. Professor Shen Jianfeng told *NewsChina* the revisions deliver timely corrective guidance to curb widespread misuse of non-compete agreements.

The SPC emphasized that talent constitutes a core strategic resource for China's modernization drive. The non-compete framework under the Labor Contract Law exists to protect corporate trade secrets and intellectual property while deterring unfair competition, not to halt the orderly flow of skilled workers. Courts hearing non-compete litigation must strike a balance between employees' rights to choose their occupation freely and legitimate market competition, enabling rational, well-organized redistribution of labor talent.

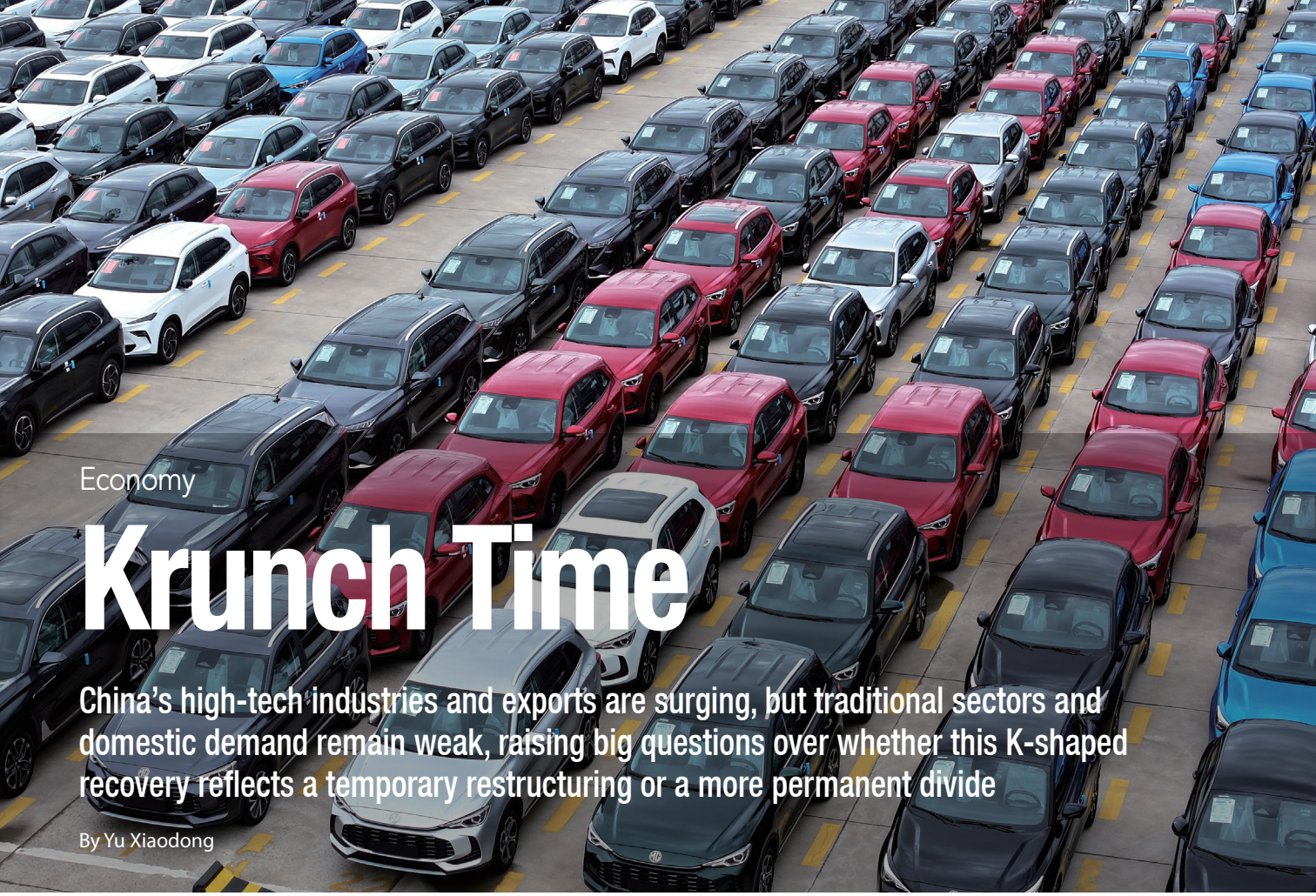
Chen Yifang, chief judge of the SPC's First Civil Division, outlined these standards at an August 2025 press conference and stressed the importance of free labor mobility for economic development. He urged courts nationwide to resolve non-compete conflicts by balancing workers' employment freedom and fair market competition, reiterating that unrestricted talent movement strengthens resource allocation, innovation and industrial upgrades.

"Since the new judicial rules went into effect, major technology corporations have drastically reduced lawsuits targeting junior-level staff," Cui said. The higher evidentiary bar now dismisses most overreaching non-compete claims during the labor arbitration phase, before cases reach court.

"Reforming this system will be a long process, yet many refinements remain necessary," legal expert Zhong Guowei said. The current regulations already explore higher mandatory non-compete compensation floors and caps on contractual liquidated damages, Zhong said.

"Rapid technological progress also raises legitimate questions over whether the standard two-year non-compete restriction period is excessively lengthy for fast-evolving industries," he added. ★

Liang Xu and Yang Jun are pseudonyms



Economy

Krunch Time

China's high-tech industries and exports are surging, but traditional sectors and domestic demand remain weak, raising big questions over whether this K-shaped recovery reflects a temporary restructuring or a more permanent divide

By Yu Xiaodong

A fleet of China-made cars wait for export at Lianyungang Port, Jiangsu Province, August 10, 2026 (Photo by VCG)

Despite a more challenging global environment, China's GDP expanded 4.7 percent year-on-year for the first half of 2026, keeping growth within the government's target range of 4.5 to 5 percent, according to National Bureau of Statistics (NBS).

However, beneath the reassuring headline figures, the latest economic data points to an increasingly uneven recovery that many economists describe as a K-shaped pattern.

Unlike a V-shaped or U-shaped recovery, where most sectors rebound together, a K-shaped one sees some parts of the economy expand while others experience sluggish growth or even decline.

Two-speed Recovery

The NBS data shows that China's growth is increasingly concentrated in a handful of technology-driven sectors while traditional industries and domestic demand continue to struggle.

In the first half of 2026, China's high-tech manufacturing grew 13.3 percent year-on-year, while equipment manufacturing and electronics manufacturing expanded by 9.3 percent and 14.8 percent respectively, well above the 5.4 percent growth in the value added of industrial enterprises above designated size (those with an annual revenue above US$3m). By comparison, some traditional industries performed far less impressively: mining grew by just 3.6 percent.

The service sector exhibited a similar pattern. While the sector grew 5.2 percent and contributed 66.1 percent of overall economic growth, information transmission, software and IT services expanded 10.7 percent, while leasing and business services grew 11.9 percent, reflecting strong demand for producer services as industrial upgrading gathers pace. By contrast, growth in several more traditional service industries remained comparatively subdued, with transport, storage and postal services expanding only 4.7 percent.

The divergence is even more striking on the demand side. External demand remained a major source of growth, with total foreign trade rising 16.9 percent to a record 25.47 trillion yuan (US$3.75t) in the first half of the year, with exports and imports up by 13.4 percent and 22.1 percent respectively.

The export surge was led by high-tech products, whose exports increased by 39 percent. Integrated-circuit exports jumped 96.1 percent year-on-year, making them China's largest single export commodity for the first time in June. Exports of automatic data-processing equipment and related products, including computers and servers, rose 41.3

percent. Mechanical and electrical products grew 20.1 percent and accounted for 63.5 percent of total exports.

As high-tech industries have surged ahead in both domestic and external markets, the benefits have accrued largely to specialized manufacturers and large equipment makers. Many traditional small and micro enterprises are trapped in cutthroat competition, with profit margins steadily eroding. This has led to weak domestic demand. Retail sales rose only 1.3 percent in the first half of the year, with per capita consumer spending increasing only 2.7 percent in real terms, slowing to 2.0 percent among urban residents.

The prolonged property downturn continues to weigh on both investment and household confidence. Real estate development investment fell 18 percent, while the value of new commercial housing sales declined 13.6 percent. Infrastructure and manufacturing investment also fell 2.4 percent and 1.2 percent respectively. All this led to a decline of 5.7 percent in total fixed-asset investment excluding rural households, with private investment recording a deeper decline of 8.5 percent.

Meanwhile, industrial capacity utilization fell to 73 percent in the second quarter, its lowest level since Q2 2020, reinforcing official assessments that the economy continues to face a pronounced imbalance between strong supply and weak domestic demand.

'Short-term Growing Pains'

Economies at the forefront of the latest technological revolution have also experienced widening gaps between fast-growing technology industries and more traditional sectors. In the US, for example, AI has widened this gap over the past few years. South Korea has experienced a similar divide as booming semiconductor exports increasingly contrast with sluggish domestic demand.

But some economists argue that China's economy differs from other major economies in significant ways.

Speaking at the 121st China Macroeconomy Forum (CMF) seminar in June 2026, Wu Ge, chief economist at Changjiang Securities, argued that while the US' K-shaped pressures stem from a series of supply-side cost shocks, China's are driven primarily by weak demand.

In the US, while technology and AI investment have driven growth, higher energy prices, tariffs and other factors have pushed up production costs and consumer prices. In China, strong exports and growth in high-tech and emerging industries have supported the economy, but domestic demand, including consumption and investment, has failed to keep pace.

The bigger question for economists is whether the K-shaped pattern is a transitional feature of structural adjustment or could harden into a longer-term divide. Some warn that the divergence could weigh on employment and consumer confidence, further weakening domestic demand and reinforcing the pattern.

Others argue that China is undergoing a longer-term shift from a manufacturing-led economy toward one increasingly centered on services and advanced industries.

"It is a misinterpretation to treat the short-term 'temperature gap' created by structural adjustment as a permanent structural divide," said Liu Yijun, an economist from the Capital University of Economics and Business in Beijing, in an article on *Beijing Daily*'s web portal on July 23.

Liu argued that while China's emphasis on "new quality productive forces" has led to rapid growth of new industries and business models, these drivers have yet to reach a scale and level of maturity sufficient to fully offset the adjustment of traditional ones. "The shift from old to new growth engines is rarely a smooth handover," Liu said.

Describing the current problems as "short-term growing pains," Liu argued that with the right policies, China's ongoing industrial transformation will be able to help raise total factor productivity and improve the quality and sustainability of growth in the long run.

Liu's view was echoed by Liao Qun, chief economist at Hong Kong's Sino Group. In a column published on Sina.com on July 23, Liao argued that China's K-shaped recovery reflects two structural transitions taking place simultaneously.

The first is the technological shift driven by the digital and green revolutions, which is contributing to K-shaped divergences globally. The second is China's longer-term industrial upgrading from an economy dominated by lower-end manufacturing toward one increasingly driven by services and high-end manufacturing. While this transition has largely been completed in developed economies, Liao noted, it is still unfolding in China.

"The overlapping of these two transformations makes China's K-shaped economic divergence especially pronounced," Liao said. As both are "inevitable" trends for China's future economic development, he argued, K-shaped divergence is a "positive, forward-looking, and aggressive" form of development rather than a sign of economic failure.

The policy challenge is to strengthen the links between the old and new. Liao called for traditional industries to be upgraded through digital and green technologies, while encouraging emerging industries to create new sources of employment and absorb workers displaced by the structural shift.

Boosting Consumption

Whether it is transitional or long term, there is consensus among economists and policymakers that the immediate impact of the divergence on growth prospects and people's livelihoods is a concern.

On August 1, an editorial published by *Qiushi*, the Communist Party of China's flagship journal, framed the discussion in terms of the gap between

macroeconomic data and people's lived experiences.

While stressing the economy's resilience, it urged to "pay close attention to the difficulties and challenges facing the economy," while "remaining confident, confronting them head-on and making the most of the opportunities and advantages available."

More specifically, it called for faster adoption of new technologies in traditional industries, better market-based resource allocation and fewer barriers to technological application, so that AI and other emerging technologies can benefit a broader range of businesses and workers.

"The transition between old and new growth drivers is at a critical stage, making it all the more important to keep growth stable, maintain the economy within a reasonable range and use economic stability to safeguard people's livelihoods and improve their well-being through development," the editorial said.

On July 13, the State Council, China's cabinet, approved the 15th Five-Year Plan for Expanding Consumption, which sets a 2030 retail sales target of 60 trillion yuan (US$8.85t), nearly 20 percent higher than the 2025 level.

The plan, the first of its kind, sets out 28 key tasks across six areas, with a strong focus on boosting household spending power and expanding services consumption. It calls for more stable employment, higher minimum wages and greater household property income, while pledging to strengthen social security and increase public spending on education, healthcare and eldercare to ease household burdens. The plan seeks to raise the share of household spending on services through expanded offerings in eldercare, childcare, culture and tourism, health and sports.

How these plans are implemented will be crucial in determining whether China's K-shaped divergence will persist.★

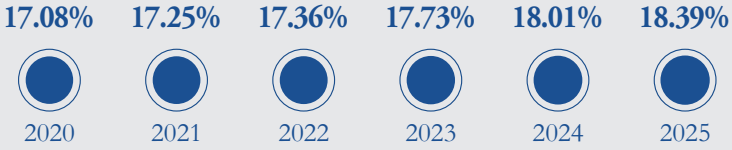
China By Numbers

18.39%

Share of the added value of the "Three New" economy – new industries, new business formats and new business models – in China's GDP in 2025, a rise of 0.38 percentage points over 2024

Source: National Bureau of Statistics of China

Share of the added value of the "Three New" economy between 2020 and 2025



1.23%

Year-on-year growth in the consumption of gold in the first half of 2026, totaling 511.4 tons

Source: China Gold Association

Year-on-year change in different types of gold consumption in the first half of 2026

5%

Year-on-year rise in the added value of China's light industry above designated size (with annual revenue over US$3m) in the first half of 2026, totaling 11.2 trillion yuan (US$1.7t)

Source: China National Light Industry Council

3%

Appreciation of the yuan against the US dollar by the end of June over the end of 2025, while the CFETS index, which measures the currency's performance against a basket of major trading partners' currencies, rose by 4.7 percent over the same period

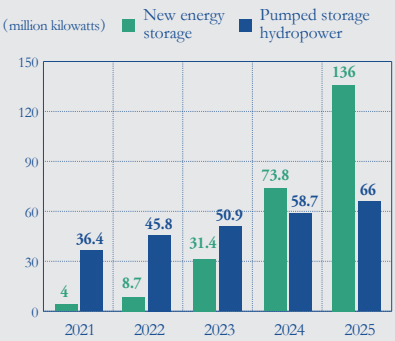
Source: The People's Bank of China

136 million kilowatts

China's installed capacity of new energy storage in 2025, more than twice the installed capacity of pumped-storage hydropower

Source: National Energy Administration of China

Installed capacity of new energy storage and pumped storage hydropower between 2021 and 2025



Film

Tickets to Paradise

A new animated film gives Taoism's Eight Immortals a very human origin story, and sends curious tourists looking for their mythical home

By Yi Ziyi

Poster of *All Wishes Come True!*

In Penglai, the legendary paradise of Chinese mythology, the gods have KPIs to meet.

They clock in for work from 9 to 6 every day, receive performance evaluations and are assigned temples according to the amount of incense their worshippers offer.

When a mortal makes a wish, the gods are expected to fulfill it, no matter how absurd the request. In one scene, a worshipper asks for a rooster to lay eggs.

This is the irreverent world of *All Wishes Come True!*, a new animated feature that reimagines one of China's best-known folk legends, the Eight Immortals.

Produced by Pearl Studio, the creatives behind *Kung Fu Panda 3*, *Abominable* and the Oscar-nominated *Over the Moon*, the film tells the origin story of the eight legendary figures by presenting them not as powerful immortals, but as a ragtag crew of characters who manage to outwit powerful gods and ultimately earn their divine status.

The approach went viral on social media. Positive buzz from advance screenings prompted producers to move up the film's release a week to July 18. It went on to gross 400 million yuan (US$58.9m) in its first five days and had reached 1.1 billion yuan (US$163m) by August 2, making it the highest-grossing animated film of the summer season.

But despite its commercial success, the film has caught criticism. Some have taken issue with its depiction of deities in the Taoist pantheon, raising debate over how far filmmakers can reinvent a traditional legend before audiences push back.

Legends in the Making

The Eight Immortals is one of China's most iconic folk legends, appearing in oral traditions, operas, paintings and literature over the centuries.

The best-known story, "The Eight Immortals Crossing the Sea," is detailed

in the Ming Dynasty (1368-1644) novel *Dongyouji* (*Journey to the East*) by Wu Yuantai.

Each is a legend in his own right. Li Tieguai is a beggar with an iron crutch who heals the sick. Bare-bellied Zhongli Quan has a magic fan that can revive the dead. Eccentric Zhang Guolao rides his white mule backward. The group's leader, Lü Dongbin, wields a magic sword that repels evil.

After attending a grand gathering of immortals on Mount Penglai, the crew decides to return to the mortal world by crossing the East China Sea. To make the trip, each demonstrates their unique magical abilities: Li Tieguai turns his crutch into a boat, Zhongli Quan floats on his fan and Zhang Guolao rides his donkey on the waves.

The tale spawned the common Chinese idiom, "When the Eight Immortals cross the sea, each displays their own magical powers," which is used to describe people drawing on their individual talents and strengths to accomplish a shared goal.

Part of the Eight Immortals' appeal comes from their humble origins. Unlike other heavenly deities, they are mortals from different backgrounds who attained immortality through cultivating virtue and overcoming hardship.

It is this largely unexplored period of their lives that director and screenwriter Mu Zhengyang wanted to bring to the screen.

"Everyone has heard the story of 'the Eight Immortals Crossing the Sea,' but very few people know what they actually went through before attaining immortality," Mu wrote in an article published in the *People's Daily*. "So we want to fill in that missing chapter."

The film begins with Taoist swordsman Lü Dongbin enlisting Zhongli Quan, a cursed wanderer living as a thief, to break into the divine treasury on Penglai and recover a magical lamp. Along the way, they recruit six more companions who together plan to pull an Ocean's Eleven-style heist while posing as immortals.

Their change from schemers to celestials is central to Mu's adaptation.

"In my view, the Eight Immortals are a rare group in Chinese mythology that embodies 'mortals attaining immortality.' They were not born as deities, nor did they possess innate magical powers," Mu wrote. "They were ordinary people who emerged from the mundane world, each with their own background, trade and flaws."

The film takes that idea further by giving Penglai a touch of the mundane. Instead of an infinite paradise, Penglai is a sprawling bureaucracy. Heavenly officials deal with complaints, chase quotas and struggle with the trivial frustrations of office life. Interestingly, Taoist traditions themselves often portray the heavens with departments, officials and courts that mirror the earthly realm.

The joke has landed well with younger audiences, who shared their stories on social media comparing the film's Penglai to their own workplaces.

"That scene where Cao Guojiu (an administrator in Penglai and one of the Eight Immortals) makes a routine office call and has to fake a polite voice while not smiling was so relatable to an office drone like me," Yvonne commented on RedNote.

Film critic Chen Tong called it one of the film's most creative elements. "The concept is both funny and an imaginative fusion of mythology and contemporary life," he told *NewsChina*.

Just Like Heaven

The film also impressed viewers with its striking visuals. The animation team drew inspiration from classical murals, traditional color palettes and landscape paintings to create an aesthetic that feels both authentically Chinese and distinctly modern.

According to Mu, the film's signature iridescent look, from the immortals' outfits to Penglai itself, comes from descriptions in ancient Taoist texts.

"They often describe immortals as 'radiant and shimmering with flowing light,' and we translated that imagery into a visual language suited to contemporary audiences," Mu wrote. "The immortals' robes shimmer as the light changes, capturing the ethereal elegance of classical depictions while showcasing modern craftsmanship."

Mu added that, in designing Penglai, the creative team referenced the colored glaze and gemstone textures of the *Malachite Inlaid Jewel Penglai Fairyland Landscape*, a Qing Dynasty (1644-1911) artifact housed in the Palace Museum in Beijing.

"The iridescence is a refined take on traditional folk culture. It preserves the bold colors of New Year paintings and the rustic textures of folk artifacts while reinterpreting them through modern aesthetics and technology," Mu said.

Combined with the blue-green palette of traditional *shanshui* landscape painting, Penglai takes on the warm, translucent luster of jade, the director wrote.

Down to Earth

The film's Penglai may be legend, but the name belongs to a real place.

Penglai, now a district in the city of Yantai, East China's Shandong Province, has long been associated with the mythical island where the Eight Immortals are said to have gathered before crossing the sea.

The film appears to be giving that connection a fresh boost. According to travel platform Tongcheng Travel, searches and bookings for scenic attractions in Penglai rose by more than 70 percent year-on-year in July. Visitor numbers and spending on dining, accommodation and cultural products have also increased, according to the platform.

Local authorities have been quick to capitalize on the interest. The Yantai Bureau of Culture and Tourism

announced that moviegoers can receive discounts or free admission at nearly 20 scenic spots across the city by presenting their ticket for the film.

Among the attractions is Penglai Pavilion, a site built in 1061 and associated with the Eight Immortals' legendary journey.

The story is also poised to cross even larger seas, with *All Wishes Come True!* slated for screenings in more than 10 countries and regions in August, from the US, UK and Australia to Papua New Guinea and Luxembourg.

Keeping it Real

The film received widespread praise from both critics and audiences, earning an 8.2 out of 10 on Douban, China's leading film review platform.

"A fantasy film in appearance, a heist film in structure and a martial arts film in spirit. This time, it moves beyond the familiar rallying cry of 'I am the master of my own fate' and instead tells a grounded, heartfelt story about human relationships. It's a remarkably successful genre film," wrote Douban user Tianmaxing.

"What excites me most is that Chinese animation finally has a story worthy of such stunning visuals. The suspense is sustained throughout, and the twists in the middle and at the end are both surprising and satisfying. Although the story is largely original, it captures the essence of the legend: the Eight Immortals are ordinary people from the mortal world, each with a distinct personality," wrote another user Lixiaodiu.

Nevertheless, some viewers criticized the film for misrepresenting revered figures from Chinese mythology such as Yang Jian, a god known for his truth-seeing third eye.

"The film portrays Yang Jian as a ruthless villain who wants to use a magical lamp to sacrifice all mortals in an attempt to resurrect his deceased mother. That goes too far. In Chinese mythology, Yang Jian is a hero and a protector of humanity," Yang Xin, a 28-year-old from Hunan Province and an avid Hanfu enthusiast with a strong interest in Chinese mythology, told *NewsChina*.

Yang also took issue with the film's rendering of the Three Gods of Fortune, Prosperity and Longevity, which are among the most widely worshipped Taoist deities.

People in costume pose for photos at a display promoting *All Wishes Come True!* at an event in Wuhan, Hubei Province, August 5, 2026 (Photo by VCG)

"Many people still display their statues or portraits at home. But in the film, they are depicted as greedy, selfish and unlikeable. I think that portrayal shows little respect for our traditional culture," Yang said.

Some of the criticisms have more to do with storytelling. Critic Chen pointed to inconsistencies in the characters and their motivations.

"The film presents the Eight Immortals as flawed, self-interested people, but it doesn't provide enough key turning points to convincingly explain how they become such a close-knit group. The transformation isn't fully developed," Chen said.

"Characters such as Li Tieguai begin as selfish swindlers motivated purely by money and treasure. Yet in the second half of the film, they suddenly become willing to sacrifice their lives to save humanity. That shift in motivation feels abrupt and unearned."

The debate reflects an age-old problem filmmakers face when revisiting ancient myths.

British director Christopher Nolan's retelling of the ancient Greek epic *The Odyssey* has drawn criticism for its departures from Homer's text. Released the same weekend as *All Wishes Come True!*, it similarly stirred controversy for its changes to characters, events and the role of the gods.

Though different in their approaches, both directors faced the same challenge of choosing what to preserve and how to bring new life to the tale for modern audiences.

For Mu Zhengyang, the choice was returning to its human core. After all, the Immortals were once ordinary people. "And that is precisely the most fascinating part of their story," Mu wrote. "They each had their own agendas, undermined one another and argued constantly. Yet it was precisely these imperfect people who, at critical moments, chose to stand by one another and turn the impossible into reality."★

Students from China and the US shake hands at the first US-China Youth Pickleball Friendship Tournament held in Montgomery County, Maryland, US, February 7, 2026. The match was part of a 10-day visit by 24 students from Shanghai Luwan Senior High School to the US from February 3, which also took them to New York, Philadelphia and Washington, DC (Photo by Matthew Zheng Xia)

Serving up Friendship

US youth pickleball delegations to China are continuing the connections started by Ping-Pong Diplomacy 55 years ago, and building a legacy of relationships for years to come, says American athletics administrator Jeffrey Sullivan

By Chen Mengtong

Fifty-five years after Ping-Pong Diplomacy helped break the ice between China and the US in April 1971, pickleball is now writing the next chapter of bilateral people-to-people exchange between the two countries. In February, Jeffrey Sullivan, systemwide athletics director for Montgomery County Public Schools in Maryland, US, led a 45-member youth pickleball delegation to China during the Spring Festival, traveling from Shenzhen, South China's Guangdong Province, to Beijing, experiencing authentic Chinese culture along the way. In April 2025, Sullivan led a pickleball delegation of 44 teachers and students from 13 US schools to China for the first time, under Chinese President Xi Jinping's "50,000 in Five Years" initiative that aims to bring 50,000 young Americans to China for exchange and study programs over five years.

Pickleball is a fast-paced sport, but easy to learn, according to the USA Pickleball website. It is played indoors or outside on a badminton-sized court, in singles or doubles, using a paddle and plastic ball with holes in.

After visiting Shanghai, Shenzhen and Beijing, the delegation sent a letter to Xi, expressing their gratitude for the initiative. In his reply in early July 2025, Xi said he was pleased to see that pickleball has become a new bond for youth exchanges between China and the US. In return, young Chinese students from Shenzhen and Shanghai visited Montgomery and several other places in the US, including Boston, New York, Philadelphia and Washington, DC, in 2025 and 2026 to continue the friendship of young people from the two countries on and off pickleball courts.

Sullivan has frequently described his Chinese trips as "life-changing" for the students and himself. Recently, Sullivan told China News Service (CNS) how pickleball can boost people-to-people exchange between the two countries and continue the bilateral connection

formed by Ping-Pong Diplomacy more than five decades ago.

Sullivan stressed that cultural exchanges have made their visits "more than a trip," noting that more than a year since their first trip, students from the US and China are still communicating through WeChat. All those friendships and experiences are "genuine," and that's the "cool part of it," he said.

Sports Director Jeffrey Sullivan in his office, Montgomery County, Maryland, US, June 3, 2026 (Photo by CNS)

China News Service: What was your impression from the two visits to China?

Jeffrey Sullivan: My understanding and my experiences in China have been incredible. I've used the word "magical" before. The hospitality we received on both of our trips was amazing.

On our first trip, going to Shanghai, Shenzhen and Beijing, pickleball diplomacy was really born. The connections that were made, the friendships that last to this day and will continue, and the ability to embrace Chinese culture really made a strong impact on us in that first trip.

The second trip, returning to Shenzhen and having smaller city experiences like Shangyou (Jiangxi Province) and Hebi (Henan Province), and returning to Beijing, was just next level because we visited during the Spring Festival. Being able to celebrate that holiday in China was simply out of this world.

What really said home for us was how many Chinese people, at every stop, during a time when they were supposed to be resting, relaxing and spending time with their own families, were making us feel at home and feel like family.

My experience in China has been incredible, and I'm very excited to return there soon.

CNS: Was there a particular moment in China that touched you?

JS: I don't know if there was one particular moment. I think it was watching the countless friendships between our student ambassadors and their friends in China every step of the way.

That started immediately when we got off the bus at the first stop on both trips. Watching that happen, I was overwhelmed with joy.

Being on the Great Wall of China with my daughter is a moment I'll remember for the rest of my life. She grabbed me by the shoulders at one point and said, "Dad, close your eyes." I closed my eyes, and she said, "We're on the Great Wall of China. I don't want you to ever forget this moment."

I had tears in my eyes.

There are a lot of memories on the trips, but I think the hospitality and the welcome we got in every location have been incredible. It's something that has set the stage for pickleball diplomacy to continue to be successful.

CNS: What makes an experience like this so powerful that you've described these trips many times as "life-changing?"

JS: I think it's traveling around the world to a new country that, for most of our ambassadors, including me – last April was my first time in China – and embracing another culture and learning.

And for me, it's not just about the trip. What's made our initiative so successful is the lead-up to each of these trips, the preparation. It's no different from preparing for a big game in sports, all the practices and the preparation. When it comes time for the game, you play well. In addition to pickleball events, the most important part was the cultural learning sessions that we had and the preparation for the trip. Those activities created a third thing – relationships, and building a family among our delegation. That created strong bonds between our [student] ambassadors and between the adults and me as well. And when we arrived in China, we were able to focus solely on building relationships, embracing culture and being part of a life-changing experience.

CNS: Why do you think firsthand experiences like these are so important?

JS: Because the experiences are genuine, so you're able to see people. Despite the differences in cultures, politics and all the things between countries, the roots are the people. Having that people-to-people connection and building those relationships and understanding culture and taking an intentional interest in learning someone else's culture

is a powerful thing. It's a life skill that doesn't just apply to the US and China. It applies to here at home in your school, in your community, with friends and with co-workers.

Those are life skills about taking an intentional interest in someone else's culture who may be different. How do you build a relationship? And how do you identify similarities and build bridges? I believe that through pickleball diplomacy, we're embracing those life skills and the mindset that has allowed our student ambassadors to change and grow.

I've heard the phrase "life-changing" being used countless times with our student ambassadors and with their parents, and with me. This experience has changed my life and my outlook on a lot of things. I want to continue to make those life changing experiences for our student ambassadors and for countless people.

CNS: What is the biggest challenge your students face when they are trying to understand China?

JS: I think initially it's more of not knowing, not understanding the history, of the culture of China and learning that piece of it. I think it's more of unknown versus a negative perception.

What we look for in our [student] ambassadors is the willingness to learn about culture and about China. So that's been part of our preparation for our trips.

CNS: Of all the possible ways to connect young people, what makes sports, pickleball in particular, so effective?

JS: Sports bring people together. They bring countries together. You can see that on the grandest stage, the Olympics, where nations come together every four years to compete and join together. That's the international level. You can also see here at the high school level how sports play an important role in school culture in bringing the school communities and the schools together to compete.

I believe in the power of sports to bring people together and showcase the ability to learn, to celebrate wins and to handle defeat with dignity.

So you learn all the lessons in sports in teamwork. That plays into a sport like pickleball. One of the things about sports is that people are afraid to fail. Or sports sometimes can be hard to pick up and master. Pickleball is a sport that's easy to pick up. Because of that quick entry point, the ability to quickly pick up a paddle and experience success, most people can get through that anxiety period rather quickly.

We've had [student] ambassadors on both trips who had never played pickleball before. But they picked up a paddle and said "I like this. This is cool." And the sport itself plays out perfectly for something like what we're doing, because a doubles team plays a doubles team – Chinese and Americans play side by side. They play in this team and they compete on the court. And what we see is instantaneously the teamwork, the sportsmanship, the special handshakes, the tapping of the paddles. And they communicate on the court, like who's going to be on what side. All of that happened quickly. So pickleball emerged to be a great sport because of that. The competition occurred, and the friendships were still there.

For us, in Montgomery County Public Schools, we were the first school district in the US to have pickleball as our city sport. That's what initially brought attention to us and opened the door for pickleball diplomacy to happen.

CNS: What role do youth exchanges play in the future relationship between the two countries?

JS: I would 100 percent encourage more youth exchange programs. I think it provides an opportunity to learn, to grow, to build a shared understanding for the future. Our youth are the future.

Sports are one pathway. But there are also opportunities through the arts and music as well. There are a lot of ways to connect. I think the more we can connect, the better.

For us, in one small way, all the relationships we built are building bridges and building bonds. The world is a happier place when we are doing it. We're happy to be part of it.

CNS: Ping-Pong Diplomacy has lasted for 55 years. Looking 20 years into the future, what do you hope today's students on both sides will remember about their journeys?

JS: I hope all the friendships are continuing to grow and blossom.

I hope that they carry the memories that they have with them and also tell the stories. I think it's important to tell the story of what pickleball diplomacy was about. So my hope is, as I said at the airport after our first trip, "The trip may be over, but our legacy will live on."

Whatever that legacy is, I think it's been a positive one to this point of being an activity and an experience that builds bridges and bonds and friendships that are genuine.

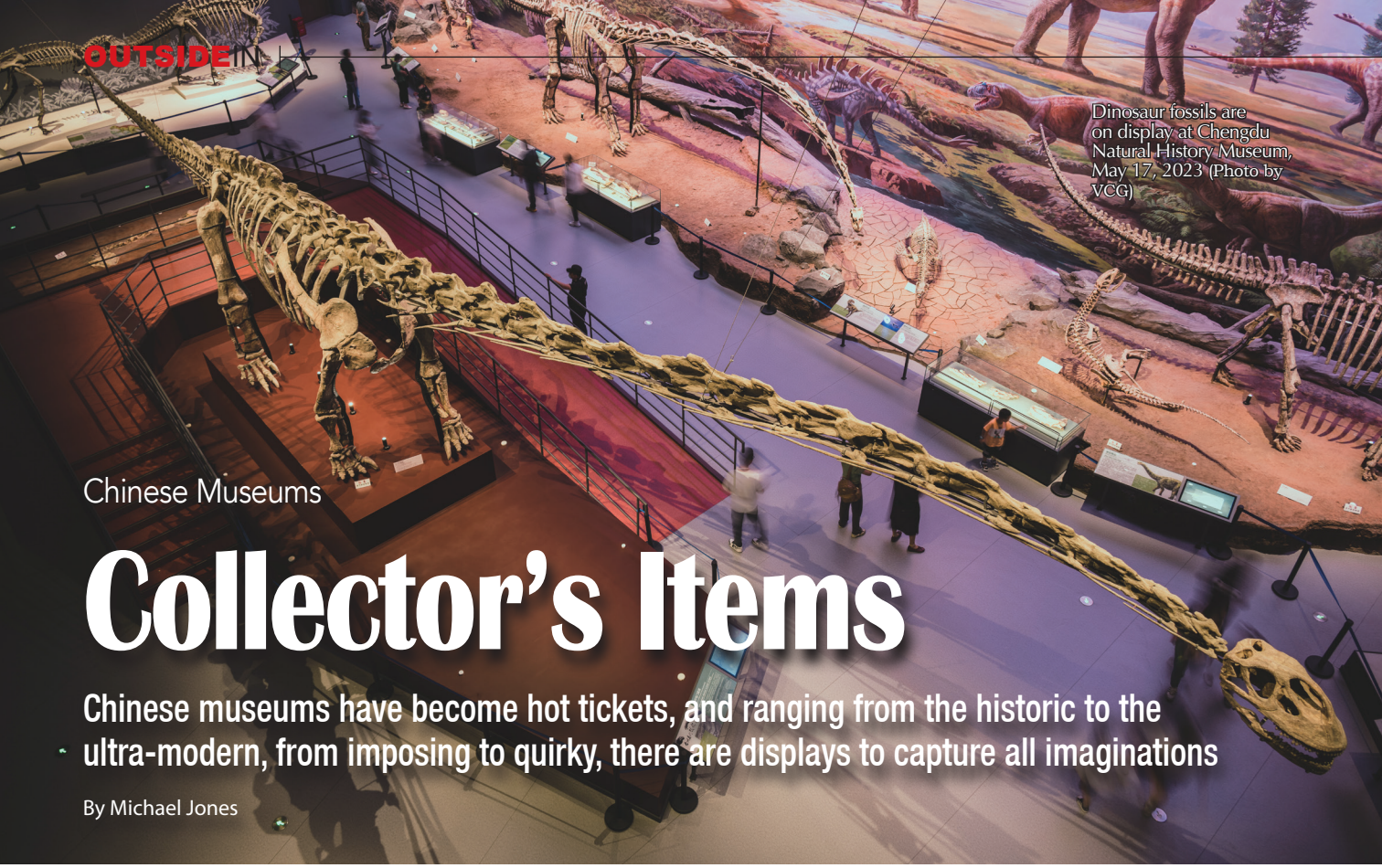
Our students use the term "aura" all the time – the aura around you, the vibes of what you do. So we talk about the aura of pickleball diplomacy.

It's not just about pickleball, or diplomacy or about sport. It's the aura around. It's the connection and the feeling. So you live pickleball diplomacy. That's what we say and we believe our [student] ambassadors have brought that to life.

My role is to create the spaces for that to happen. I help lead and get out of the way to let our students do their thing. That's been the cool part of it.

It's gonna be cool to watch it and continue to build.★

This article was originally published by W.E. TALK, a China News Service production. Reprinted with permission from CNS



Dinosaur fossils are on display at Chengdu Natural History Museum, May 17, 2023 (Photo by VCG)

Chinese Museums

Collector's Items

Chinese museums have become hot tickets, and ranging from the historic to the ultra-modern, from imposing to quirky, there are displays to capture all imaginations

By Michael Jones

Museums are gateways to the past. They are places where objects, stories and ideas allow us to step beyond the boundaries of our own time. It's why I have always loved museums, and thankfully, China has an extraordinary variety of them. Indeed, many of the world's largest and most visited museums are in China. From the 7 million annual visitors who experience the massive National Museum of China in Beijing which covers almost 200,000 square meters, to the 6 million visitors who enjoy the 85,000 square meters of the Nanjing Museum, in Nanjing, Jiangsu Province, China has plenty of mega-museums to explore.

In fact, according to the Themed Entertainment Association (TEA), 14 of the top 20 museums in the world are in China, with the three most visited museums in the world all in the country. According to TEA, the Louvre Museum in Paris, France, long regarded as the world's most visited museum, has now been overtaken by the Palace Museum (Forbidden City) in Beijing, which sees 17 million annual visitors, while the honor of second-most visited museum in the world has been claimed by Chengdu Wuhou Shrine Museum, with Emperor Qinshihuang's Mausoleum Site Museum in Xian, Shaanxi Province, coming in third.

Gallery to History

However, China is also home to many smaller, less internationally famous museums, which are often rather unique. In many ways these smaller museums offer an even more intriguing insight into Chinese life and Chinese culture than their larger cousins. One of my favorites is the Former Qing Dynasty Post Office, which is in Zhujiajiao Ancient Water Town near Shanghai. Although the museum covers only 70 square meters, it offers a fascinating glimpse into how daily life in China slowly modernized across the eras of the Qing Dynasty (1644-1911), the Republic of China period (1912-1949) and the early stages of the People's Republic of China (1949-present).

Another fascinating museum is Gulangyu Piano Museum, located on Gulangyu Island, Xiamen in Southeast China's Fujian Province. This intriguing museum presents, displays and promotes the island's unique musical tradition, which fuses European and Chinese elements. The museum includes two separate buildings, which are filled with an assortment of rare and magnificent pianos including everything from miniature models to elongated grands. Many of the items in the collection feature intricate and colorful designs. The Piano Museum is directly connected to Shu Zhuang Garden, an eccentric paradise of curiosities, with a single ticket required for visitors to enjoy both attractions.

China also has several major museums that are dedicated to specific historical figures or events.

These include the Museum of Dr Sun Yat-sen in Zhongshan and the Opium War Museum in Dongguan, both in South China's Guangdong Province, and the Military Museum of the Chinese People's Revolution in Beijing. These museums highlight the incredible importance of certain events and individuals in shaping the course of Chinese history. Spending time understanding these museums and their contents is one of the most accessible ways for international visitors to better appreciate how the events of the past have shaped modern Chinese people and modern Chinese culture.

For those interested in Chinese military history there is no shortage of museums to whet their appetite. Within the category of military history, my personal favorite is Zhongshan Warship Museum in Wuhan, Central China's Hubei Province. This museum has been entirely constructed around the *SS Zhongshan*, a massive Chinese gunboat built in 1910, which was sunk by the Japanese in October 1938 during the Battle of Wuhan. The wreck was salvaged from the bottom of the Yangtze River on January 28, 1997, before being relocated to its present site. As a time-capsule, visibly representing an important period in Chinese history, the Zhongshan now stands at the heart of this fascinating museum. Today, the monumental ship is surrounded by the stories of those who experienced the terrors, virtues and upheavals of that pivotal era.

Jurassic Past

However, not all museums in China are dedicated to the story of human history. Some of the most fascinating museums in China are part of the country's collection of natural history museums.

Tourists visit Gulangyu Piano Museum, Xiamen, Fujian Province, July 24, 2022 (Photo by VCG)

Established museums include the Chengdu Natural History Museum, Sichuan Province, which includes one of the largest substantially complete dinosaur fossils in Asia, the Chongqing Natural History Museum, which has an excellent collection of Jurassic-era fossils, and the Shanghai Natural History Museum, one of China's leading museum attractions. I should also add to this list the Shenzhen Natural History Museum in Guangdong, which only opened in July 2026. Although I have not yet had the chance to visit this new museum, it promises excellence, with a massive building area of over 100,000 square meters. Nevertheless, of all the museums in China dedicated to nature, the National Natural History Museum in Beijing remains my personal favorite, in large part thanks to the ginormous and terrifying animatronic dinosaurs, which inhabit the atrium's jungle.

If you are looking for something a little more offbeat, unusual or quirky, there are plenty of curious and unusual museums and exhibitions in China. One that I enjoyed recently is the Nanyue King Museum in Guangzhou, which includes an extensive exhibition of ceramic pillows. Needless to say, the idea of sleeping on a cold solid block of ceramic directly challenges every notion of comfort and sleep that I have learned in my life thus far. However, my favorite "niche" museum in China is the Yak Museum of Lhasa, capital of Xizang Autonomous Region, which charts the extensive, historic and symbiotic relationship between the yak and the people who cohabit the plateau.

Fortunately, there are still plenty of other unique museums that I am yet to explore, but keen to experience. Morbid fascination means that I am especially looking forward to visiting Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region Museum in Urumqi, which comes highly recommended in part due to its display of well-preserved, and interestingly dressed, corpses known as the Tarim Basin Mummies. I also have a (possibly unhealthy) curiosity about the China Abacus Museum in Nantong, Jiangsu Province, which claims to be the foremost museum in the world dedicated entirely to the abacus. However, the next museum I intend to visit is the China Watermelon Museum in Beijing, which celebrates China's long and intriguing relationship with watermelon cultivation, and probably deserves the prize for the oddest and most niche museum in all of China.★

Practicalities

Tickets to Chinese museums can be bought through travel platforms like Trip, museum mini-apps on WeChat or at the museum itself. Some larger museums will require identification such as a passport and reservation in advance, such as the National Museum in Beijing or the Palace Museum. Special exhibitions may cost extra.

Navel Gazing

By Mina Yan

Honestly, I never really gave this much thought until recently. When I did, I just shrugged and figured it was some quirky little habit unique to my family. But then I started noticing it everywhere and found plenty of people online pointing it out, too.

If you've spent real time around Chinese folks, you'll inevitably spot this hilarious, almost automatic ritual that kicks in the second it's time to sleep. No matter the weather or what they're wearing, they will always make sure that their belly button is under wraps. It's a whole phenomenon.

It happens even on sweltering summer nights, when the AC is broken, and you're practically melting into the mattress, arms and legs sprawl every which way to catch any whisper of cool air. Yet there's always that one tiny anchor: a thin sliver of blanket, the folded hem of a T-shirt, or in moments of sheer desperation even a scrap of tissue paper standing guard over that one tiny spot on the stomach. It's honestly kind of comical. A person can be completely starfished, a sweaty mess, but peek closely and that navel is safely tucked away.

I remember when I was a teenager, when crop tops were the absolute must-have. I wanted to look cool, but my internal alarm bells would ring the moment a draft hit my navel and I'd inevitably end up with diarrhea afterward. So, I did what any resourceful (or slightly paranoid) teenager would do, I slapped a giant Band-Aid right over my belly button. I looked ridiculous, but guess what? I never once got a stomach ache after a night out. I was a weird evil genius!

So, what's the real deal here? Why the collective panic over a tiny hole in the middle of our stomachs?

Traditional Chinese medicine (TCM) has a poetic answer. According to TCM, that little divot is actually a major energy hub called the *shenque* acupoint. Unlike the rest of your torso that's shielded by muscle and fat, the navel is pretty much the thinnest membrane in the neighborhood and a direct highway to your digestive organs.

There's even an old saying that "illness enters through the belly button," meaning cold and dampness can waltz right in while you're blissfully unconscious. And when you're asleep, your defenses are napping too. Your pores are wide open and your yang energy is taking a break which, according to TCM, turns you into an easy target.

Before you write this off as ancient mumbo jumbo, modern science actually gives a respectful nod to grandma's old sayings. The abdomen is packed with temperature-sensitive digestive organs. A sudden chill on that bare spot can trigger spasms, mess with your gut rhythm, and leave you bloated the next morning. So keeping that area warm overnight isn't just superstition, it's basically a low-tech heating pad strategy our ancestors figured out through everyday observation.

But honestly, growing up, I didn't do it for the science. It's a habit written into our emotional DNA.

Almost every Chinese kid knows the feeling of a parent creeping into their room around 2 am and silently tucking the loose blanket edge over your tiny tummy. On hot nights, when you protest, they'd always say, "Fine, just cover your belly." It becomes a hilarious late-night game of stealth and vigilance. That constant, loving intervention eventually melts right into your muscle memory.

So, I did what any resourceful (or slightly paranoid) teenager would do, I slapped a giant Band-Aid right over my belly button. I looked ridiculous, but guess what? I never once got a stomach ache after a night out

Even if we ignore both the old wives' tales and the peer-reviewed studies, there's still just something deeply wrong about leaving your belly button exposed. Your brain screams, "Nope, not happening!" It doesn't matter if it's the edge of a silk scarf, the corner of a pillow, a tea towel grabbed as a last resort or just your own hand. As long as that little crater is covered, the body can finally relax.

So here I am, a fully grown adult engaging in what is essentially nightly belly-button security, all because some ancestors thousands of years ago decided that a warm navel equals a good night's sleep. But let's be real, if the choice is between strutting around like a carefree model with my midriff out or avoiding a morning that feels like a tiny gremlin is using my intestines as a punching bag, I'm going with the crumpled blanket scrap every time. Call it paranoia, call it tradition, call it my inner grandma screaming from the grave, I don't care. That little cotton shield is coming with me to bed, and my stomach has never been happier. Style points? Zero. Peace of mind? Absolutely priceless.★

Phoning It In

By Suzanne Robare

I can't live without my cellphone in Beijing. No, really: without my phone, I can't order a taxi, get groceries, do my banking, or pay for anything. There are also these other wonderful features, such as a map that lets me know where I am and tells me how to get to my destination by car, bike, bus or on foot (with estimates on the time it will take as well). During Covid, a code on our phone showed if we were currently Covid-free: Without that code, we were not allowed access into public places. While that ended years ago, there are still certain locations where upon entering I freeze, panicked, wondering if my code is up to date.

My phone is never out of reach, a habit I deplore for many reasons, some of them sanitary, some of them just sane. Life doesn't function here without WeChat: I call friends through WeChat. I send messages through WeChat. I use it to order take out, translate Chinese into English, send holiday greeting replete with electronic lucky red envelops filled with electronic cash (which my godchildren appreciate more than the barrel of whiskey I bought them as an investment) and share my location. Real Time Location is my favorite: As my friend and I walk towards one another, we see each other move like cursors on an old *Donkey Kong* game. To say it's useful is an understatement.

Back in the early 90s, only a lucky few had their own telephone hard-wired into the wall in China. The phone was useless unless the telephone operator for the building was awake and felt like connecting your call. The operator, usually female, and quite likely bored out of her skull, would sometimes query the caller: Who are you? Why are you calling Liu Ayi now? Don't you know it's nap time? Sometimes the questions were so intrusive that I felt I was on trial at Nuremberg. As I stumbled through in my Level 1 Chinese, I wasn't quite sure if my calls went through out of pity or more out of shock. The pinnacle of intrusiveness was reached when my Chinese brother-in-law tried to phone his parents in Beijing from the US to tell him their granddaughter had been born. Dazed with happiness and probably sounding a bit drunk (which he was) he incautiously sounded a bit too happy, which earned him a grilling from the phone operator. Why was he calling? Was the baby a boy or a girl? Was it worth waking them up from nap time to tell them it's a girl? And finally, Where are you calling from? My brother-in-law – again, dazed with both happiness and moonshine, replied truthfully that he was calling from New York. The operator, infuriated by the idea that someone might be pranking her, snapped "Why don't you just say you're calling from Africa?" and hung up on him.

My brother-in-law – again, dazed with both happiness and moonshine, replied truthfully that he was calling from New York. The operator, infuriated by the idea that someone might be pranking her, snapped "Why don't you just say you're calling from Africa?"

I was thrilled when, in the 90s, cellphones were made available. Unfortunately, upon their first release, foreigners were allowed to buy the phone, but not the SIM card to run it. A few lucky friends of mine who worked for a telephone company had phones. As for me – well, my home didn't have even the standard model, so I had to place any calls at the local grocery store, if and when they were open. Finally, in desperation, I marched into a store selling phones and convinced the owner to sell me one. The rules must have just changed because he did sell me both phone and SIM card, although he didn't set up the messaging service. Perhaps he didn't think I deserved that luxury. Unfortunately, he didn't tell me where to pay the monthly bill, which took some doing. But I had a phone.

I was reminded of how important my phone is this weekend, when I went to a market to buy a new screen protector. Like many places dependent on tourist dollars, it was bustling with foreigners, all eagerly snapping up bargains in pearls, electronic goods, Chinese tea, dolls, cashmere, embroidered goods – in short, all of the lovely touristy things that scream "I went to China!" without us having to say a word. I saw a tourist hand a vendor a bunch of colored papers and I realized with shock it was Chinese money- cash- and my mouth dropped open. The vendor looked at me and said, "Now that we have tourists again, we need to carry cash." He seemed a bit sad. ★

The Humble Pie That Feels Like Home

By Mina Yan

Let's be real, when Chinese comfort food comes up, everyone gushes over the glamorous stuff: Dumplings, braised pork belly, those dramatic hand-pulled noodles. And hey, I love all that too. But there's one quiet, unassuming little pastry that holds a totally irreplaceable spot in the Chinese heart: the chive box, or *jiucai hezi*.

It's not fancy and there's no cool plating involved. Zero social media clout. It actually even leaves you needing a serious breath mint afterwards. And yet, this humble, pan-fried half-moon of goodness is so ridiculously comforting. Every time we've got native northern Chinese visiting from abroad, they've got to get their fill before they leave.

Back in the day, in poor northern Chinese villages, farmers didn't have access to expensive ingredients. But in spring there were plenty of wild chives. They popped up everywhere along roadsides, in backyards and between fields. They grew like weeds.

So what did clever home cooks do? They chopped those chives up, mixed them with fluffy scrambled eggs and soft vermicelli noodles, wrapped the whole savory mess in a basic wheat dough, and fried them into portable, belly-filling pies. Just good, honest fuel for a long day of work.

What started as practical peasant grub quickly spread everywhere, becoming a timeless household staple that grandmas would whip up super quickly in their kitchens.

In Chinese food culture, eating fresh early-spring chives is practically a ritual. Winter meals tend to be heavy and greasy to give you the strength you need to brave the winter cold. Then spring shows up with these vibrant greens that taste like freshness itself.

Families used to fry up a batch of chive boxes to welcome the warmer weather. Fortunately, this little guy refused to stay stuck in one season. These days, you'll see people happily devouring them for breakfast on the go, lazy lunches, casual dinners or as a late-night street snack after a few beers.

And for good reason. The golden outer shells give you this satisfying crunch with every single bite. Then you get to the filling: bright green chives with that savory kick, soft scrambled eggs and tender noodles soaking up every drop of seasoning. When done right, it's never heavy or greasy, and before you know it, you're six *jiucai hezi* in and looking for a couch to lie down on and digest.

For northern Chinese living abroad, this is one of those foods that's on the top of your to-eat list when you land in China. So why don't they just eat it in whatever country they're in? Simple. Most Western supermarkets don't carry the type of chives you need to cook *jiucai hezi*. It's got such a strong unique flavor that's rarely used in Western cooking. Even Chinese supermarkets don't always stock them. So the closest thing you could do is what our family friends did – dedicate a little patch of your garden to planting your own chives.

Chive boxes may never show up on a Michelin-starred menu or go viral as some overpriced trendy bite. But honestly, that's exactly why we love them. They don't try to impress. They don't cost a fortune. They just quietly, reliably wrap you up in warm nostalgic memories. ★

REALCHINESE

huó rén gǎn

活人感

huorengan

Human feel

As more viewers tire of AI slop featuring generic-looking faces flooding their short-video feeds, a new buzzword *huorengan*, meaning "human feel" has gained popularity.

The term emerges partly as a reaction against digital characters that, according to a commentary in Party newspaper *People's Daily*, tend to share the same idealized facial features.

In comparison, real people may not have perfect faces, but they have an emotional authenticity that virtual figures cannot easily replicate. A real performer, the comment reads, may make micro-expressions, hesitate for a split second during eye contact or speak with a trembling voice when they tear up. It is these subtle, uncalculated details that give people a sense that someone is genuinely alive and present.

Many netizens say they cannot imagine and accept a cold, machine-dominated world where AI and robots fill every corner of daily life, from shop assistants and chefs to video production and even art. Some call AI-generated works as "having no soul," saying they want to see joy, grief and weariness rooted in real-world experience. They value individuality over perfection.

This appreciation for *huorengan* could give human performers, human-made dramas and other creative industries a chance to win audiences back from increasingly advanced AI technologies. ★

Original Direct Insights into Modern China

- Generate original reports about China
- Deliver direct coverage from China
- Provide timely insights into China
- Inform leaders and executives regarding China
- Advance together with a progressive modern China
- Lead as a global premier news outlet on China

Advertising:
U.S.A.: 1-212-481-2510
Canada: 1-604-761-1231
China: 86-10-88395566

Letters to the Editor:
readers@newschinamag.com
China Newsweek Corporation
820 2nd Avenue 3B-C
New York. NY 10017 USA

Subscription, Renewal, or Change of Address:
U.S.A.: 1-212-481-2510
readers@newschinamag.com
China Newsweek Corporation
820 2nd Avenue 3B-C
New York. NY 10017 USA

www.newschinamag.com

PRSRT STD
US POSTAGE
PAID
PEWAUKEE, WI
PERMIT #1619